



THE IMPACT LEDGER

STORIES OF IMPACT. CHANGE THAT MATTERS.



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CREATE CHANGE



EARN RECOGNITION

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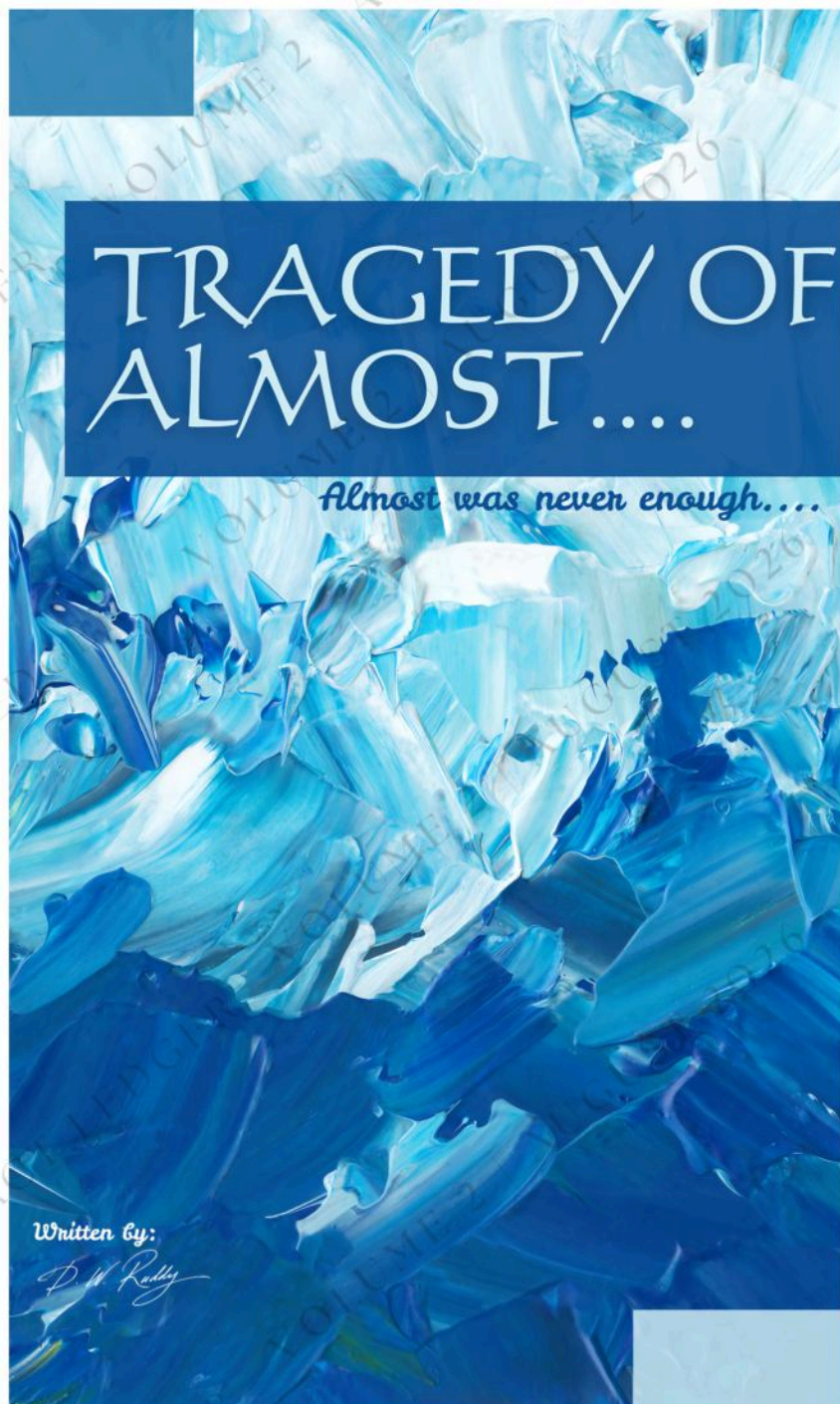


ABOUT IMPACT LEDGER

The Impact Ledger is a premium publication dedicated to celebrating impact, fostering knowledge, and inspiring meaningful change. Conceived as a platform where purpose meets perspective, the magazine brings together compelling stories of corporate social responsibility, non-governmental organisations, social entrepreneurs, visionary leaders, and changemakers transforming communities through innovation, compassion, and sustainable action. Beyond its commitment to social impact, The Impact Ledger offers a rich and diverse editorial experience, featuring national affairs, business, technology, healthcare, education, governance, public policy, sustainability, environmental conservation, sports, lifestyle, culture, and emerging innovations shaping the world around us. Every edition is thoughtfully curated with exclusive interviews, expert insights, inspiring success stories, in-depth features, thought-provoking analyses, fascinating facts, interactive quizzes, brain teasers, and knowledge-driven content designed to inform, engage, and inspire readers across generations. More than a magazine, The Impact Ledger is a trusted voice that bridges knowledge with purpose, celebrates excellence with integrity, and empowers individuals and organizations to create a lasting difference. It stands as a testament to the belief that informed minds inspire meaningful action, transformative stories shape a better future, and every edition leaves an enduring legacy of impact.

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(Monday to Saturday | 9:30 AM - 6:30 PM)
Email us at theimpactledger@gmail.com

15 Stories. 60 Pages.
**One Mission: Creating
Lasting Impact.**



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THE
IMPACT LEDGER

STORIES OF IMPACT. CHANGE THAT MATTERS.

EDITORIAL NOTE



Dear Readers,

Some stories are meant to be read. Others are meant to be remembered.

The first edition of The Impact Ledger began with a simple thought impact deserves a story, and every story of meaningful change deserves to be heard. Our intention was to create a space where the work happening around us could be looked at beyond headlines, numbers and achievements. We wanted to explore the people, ideas, efforts and purpose that make change possible.

The pages of the first edition brought together different perspectives on social responsibility, community development, sustainability, culture, creativity, environment and the changing world around us. Rather than placing impact into a single definition, the magazine looked at it from different angles and showed how change can begin in many different forms.

What made the journey meaningful was the realisation that impact does not always arrive with a spotlight. Sometimes, it grows quietly through an initiative that reaches a community, an idea that brings people together, a tradition that is kept alive, a choice that protects the environment, or an individual who simply refuses to accept that something cannot be changed.

The first edition gave us the opportunity to discover these different dimensions of impact. It reminded us that behind every achievement is effort, behind every initiative is intention, and behind every transformation are people willing to take responsibility.

It also made us look at the world with greater curiosity. The stories encouraged us to celebrate progress while also questioning what lies beneath it. They brought together stories of contribution with conversations about the challenges communities and society continue to face. In doing so, the magazine became not just a record of what is happening, but a reflection of why it matters. And now, we turn the page with an even bigger purpose.

This edition brings a wider collection of impactful stories, fresh perspectives and journeys that deserve to be discovered. We have looked further, listened more closely and sought stories that go beyond the obvious stories of people creating change, organisations building solutions, communities finding strength and ideas turning into action.

This edition brings a wider collection of impactful stories, fresh perspectives and journeys that deserve to be discovered. We have looked further, listened more closely and sought stories that go beyond the obvious stories of people creating change, organisations building solutions, communities finding strength and ideas turning into action. Our aim is not simply to bring you more stories, but to bring you stories that stay with you.

Stories that make you pause.

Stories that make you question.

Stories that make you believe.

And perhaps, stories that make you want to act.

With every edition, The Impact Ledger seeks to connect those creating change with those who need to hear their stories. We believe stories can do more than inform they can inspire conversations, shift perspectives and spark action. Impact is happening everywhere, from boardrooms to classrooms, villages to cities, through innovation, tradition, organisations and individuals. Our commitment remains to discover these stories, give them the space they deserve and celebrate those shaping a better tomorrow. Because every meaningful change begins when someone chooses to take the first step.

Lahari Rami Reddy
Editor-In-Chief
The Impact Ledger

ARUN KUMAR: THE SMILE BEHIND THE STRUGGLE

"Your struggles may shape your journey, but they never have the power to decide where your journey ends."

THE FACE BEHIND THE LAUGHTER

For millions on Instagram and across social media, Arun Kumar is known as the "Laughing Guy" or "Smiley Guy"—the young man whose effortless, infectious laughter became a viral sensation. His smile was turned into memes, reels and reaction videos, making his face recognisable far beyond his own surroundings.

But behind that laughter is a story that deserves to be known.

Arun's life was shaped by circumstances very different from the carefree image people saw online. His childhood was interrupted by financial hardship, forcing him to leave school after Class 4 at around the age of 10. While children his age continued their education, Arun stepped into the world of work as a truck cleaner.

WHEN EDUCATION BECAME A DREAM

For Arun, leaving school was not a choice born out of a lack of ambition. It was a consequence of circumstances. The classroom was replaced by highways, work and responsibility. Books gave way to the realities of earning a living. Yet somewhere beneath all of that, the possibility of education remained. His story is a reminder of how easily financial hardship can change the direction of a young person's life. For many children, school is simply part of growing up. For children facing poverty, it can become something they are forced to give up.

A SIMPLE LAUGH THAT CHANGED EVERYTHING

Arun's life took an unexpected turn during an ordinary tea break. His employer and truck driver, Nehru, captured a video of Arun laughing naturally. There was no script, no acting and no intention of creating an internet sensation.

But the internet had other plans.

The video spread rapidly, and Arun's laughter became a recognisable social-media reaction. Millions saw the smile, shared the clip and laughed along with him. Yet there was an irony in his sudden fame: the internet could read Arun's laughter, but Arun could not read the internet. Because he had left school so young, he could not fully understand the world that was suddenly talking about him.

FROM VIRAL MOMENT TO SECOND CHANCE

What began as viral fame became a life-changing opportunity. Truck driver Nehru sponsored Arun's education, covering his books and exam fees. During long journeys, the truck cabin became a classroom, turning fleeting attention into lasting mentorship and a genuine second chance.



FROM EARNING MONEY TO EARNING A FUTURE

Arun's early life teaches an important lesson about money. Money is necessary for survival, but the lack of it should never be mistaken for a lack of potential. Arun had spent years working to earn money when he should have been studying. His journey back to education showed that learning does not have an expiry date. In 2026, Arun passed his Class 10 examination, marking a remarkable milestone after years away from formal schooling. For some, passing Class 10 might appear to be an ordinary academic achievement. For Arun, it represented years of missed classrooms, difficult circumstances, hard work and the courage to begin again.

THE POWER OF BELIEF

Arun's story carries a powerful reminder: sometimes, a life changes simply because someone chooses to believe in a person's potential. Nehru did not see just a viral personality; he saw an opportunity waiting to be reclaimed. By supporting Arun's education, he turned a moment of attention into meaningful mentorship and a genuine second chance. From a truck cabin to a Class 10 certificate, Arun's journey is more than a return to school—it is a story of refusing to let the past define the future. The laughter that first made him famous now represents resilience, hope and the courage to begin again. His journey reminds us that behind every smile may be a struggle, and behind every difficult beginning may still be an unfinished dream. Sometimes, all it takes is one person to open a door and say, "You can still do this."

"It is no longer just the smile that made the internet laugh it is the smile of someone who found his way back."

— DR. NAWAB —

MIR NASIR ALI KHAN

DIPLOMACY, ENTERPRISE AND A VISION FOR THE FUTURE

Honorary Consul of Republic of Kazakhstan
for Telangana and Andhra Pradesh, India &
Promoter & Managing Director of MAK
Projects Pvt. Ltd.

A LEGACY THAT EVOLVED INTO LEADERSHIP

Dr. Nawab Mir Nasir Ali Khan represents a distinctive blend of heritage, entrepreneurship, diplomacy and responsible development. Born into a historically prominent Nawab family of Hyderabad, he grew up surrounded by stories of the Nizam era and a tradition shaped by leadership, governance, dignity and public responsibility. His upbringing gave him an appreciation for heritage, but his professional journey has been defined by his decision to build an identity of his own.

Rather than simply relying on an inherited legacy, Dr. Khan chose the path of enterprise and institution-building. His journey eventually led to the development of MAK Projects, a Hyderabad-based real estate and infrastructure enterprise focused on planned residential communities and evolving concepts of sustainable luxury. The philosophy behind his work is rooted in creating value that extends beyond the present and contributes to future generations.

His understanding of leadership has been influenced by both his heritage and his professional experiences. The values of responsibility, discipline, respect and service became important elements of his approach to business and diplomacy. His international exposure, corporate experience and interactions across cultures further broadened his perspective and strengthened his belief in collaboration.

Dr. Khan completed his education at Osmania University and subsequently gained corporate experience with Minolta, a Japanese company, where he worked in its reprographic division. His experience with the organisation provided him with exposure to advanced imaging technologies, disciplined business practices, client engagement and corporate operations. This phase played an important role in shaping his strategic thinking, professional approach and broader international outlook.

His extensive international travel through business forums, diplomatic engagements and conferences has also contributed to his understanding of different cultures and systems. These experiences have reinforced his belief that meaningful relationships, adaptability and cooperation are essential to long-term success.

DIPLOMACY BEYOND PROTOCOL

HONORARY CONSUL OF KAZAKHSTAN

Dr. Nawab Mir Nasir Ali Khan's journey extends far beyond entrepreneurship. As the Honorary Consul of the Republic of Kazakhstan in Hyderabad for Telangana and Andhra Pradesh, he occupies a distinctive position at the intersection of diplomacy, business, culture and public service. According to his professional profile, his appointment was made by the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Republic of Kazakhstan in January 2021.

His diplomatic responsibilities involve supporting stronger bilateral engagement between India and Kazakhstan across areas including trade, investment, healthcare, education, tourism, culture and people-to-people relations. Yet, for Dr. Khan, diplomacy is not limited to formal meetings, official ceremonies or protocol. It is about creating relationships that can translate into opportunities, understanding and practical cooperation.

His role provides a platform to connect businesses, institutions, cultural organisations and communities. By bringing different stakeholders together, he seeks to encourage greater awareness of the opportunities that exist between India and Kazakhstan and to contribute to a relationship that extends beyond government-to-government engagement.

CONNECTING INDIA AND KAZAKHSTAN

Dr. Khan's diplomatic vision places considerable importance on connectivity. One of the initiatives highlighted in his profile is his effort to establish direct air connectivity between Astana and Hyderabad. Such a connection has the potential to strengthen medical tourism, facilitate student exchanges, encourage business travel and create new avenues for economic and institutional cooperation. His diplomatic engagement also extends into the cultural sphere. Art, literature, textiles, cuisine and heritage provide important avenues through which communities can understand one another. India and Kazakhstan share strong growth potential across trade, energy, logistics, agriculture, healthcare, and digital services. Dr. Khan focuses on identifying these key synergies to foster long-term, sustainable strategic partnerships between both nations.



DIPLOMACY AS SERVICE

For Dr. Khan, diplomacy carries a deeply personal dimension of service that extends far beyond standard political channels. His professional journey reflects a steadfast commitment to supporting individuals during moments of acute crisis, a dedication exemplified by his hands-on assistance to vulnerable citizens during the unprecedented challenges of the COVID-19 pandemic. This pivotal experience reinforced his core conviction that effective diplomatic engagement must ultimately serve everyday people and local communities rather than remaining confined to rigid protocol and official procedures.

This human-centric philosophy infuses a meaningful, compassionate dimension into his broader diplomatic responsibilities. Within his framework, accessibility, active cooperation, and tangible assistance are valued just as highly as formal representation and high-level negotiation. By actively championing an approachable and practical model of governance, Dr. Khan ensures that diplomacy functions not merely as a bridge between sovereign governments, but as a genuine instrument for cultivating enduring trust and understanding among citizens across borders.

"The strongest diplomatic bridges are built not only between nations, but between people."

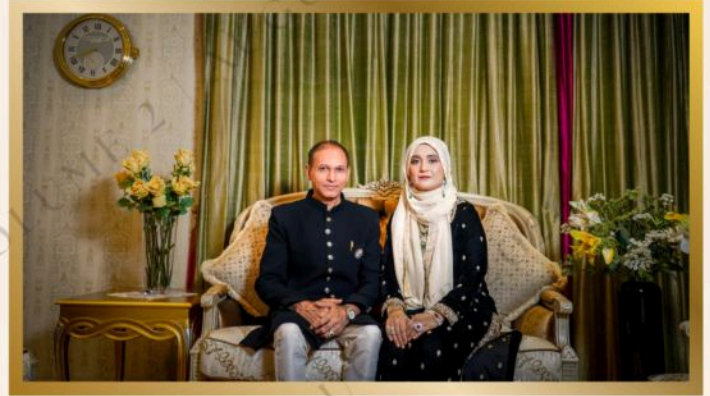
RECOGNITION ACROSS BORDERS

A career spanning diplomacy, entrepreneurship, international engagement and responsible development has brought Dr. Nawab Mir Nasir Ali Khan recognition in India and abroad. Among the honours associated with his professional journey are the Jubilee Medal of the Republic of Kazakhstan and recognition by the U.S. House of Representatives for his contribution towards strengthening India-Kazakhstan relations. Other distinctions mentioned in his professional profile include AsiaOne Person of the Year, AsiaOne Diplomatic Excellence Award, Business Leader of the Year, the Medal of Honor from India's Honorary Consular Corps, and Diplomat of the Year at Capitol Hill, Washington, D.C.

Each recognition represents a different dimension of his journey. Some reflect his contribution to international relations and cultural exchange, while others acknowledge his leadership in business and his broader professional influence. More importantly, these honours illustrate the range of responsibilities Dr. Khan has embraced over the years. His journey has not remained within a single sector. It has moved across diplomacy, enterprise, international cooperation and sustainable development, creating a professional identity built on multiple dimensions of leadership. Recognition, however, is only one measure of a career. For Dr. Khan, the greater value lies in what can be created through the opportunities that recognition brings the relationships strengthened, institutions connected, ideas exchanged and initiatives taken forward.



"True legacy is not about preserving what lies behind us, but about building with purpose to illuminate the path for those who come after."



LEADERSHIP WITH RESPONSIBILITY

For Dr. Khan, recognition is closely connected with responsibility. His upbringing in a historic Hyderabad family instilled values of humility, discipline, service and responsibility towards society. These principles have influenced his approach to both business and diplomacy. His personal interests, including automobiles, watches, writing instruments and cricket, also reflect influences from his family and upbringing. His wife, Begum Meher Fatima Khan, remains an important source of support, while his family continues to be a significant part of his life. Together, these values and relationships continue to shape his outlook, leadership and commitment to making a meaningful difference.

FROM HERITAGE TO ENTERPRISE

Creating a Legacy of His Own

For Dr. Khan, the transition from an inherited legacy to modern entrepreneurship was far more than a routine career choice; it represented a deliberate and conscious effort to forge something contemporary while honoring the foundational values of the past. During his formative college years, he was deeply influenced by an inspiring circle of peers hailing from business-oriented and entrepreneurial backgrounds. Observing their drive, independence, and forward-thinking approach inspired a fundamental shift in his own mindset encouraging him to move beyond merely preserving a family heritage and focus instead on actively building new, lasting value.

This evolving vision ultimately materialized in the establishment of MAK Projects in Hyderabad, co-founded alongside his friend and business partner, Mr. Murali Krishna Reddy. Over time, the company grew into a prominent force within the construction and real estate development sectors, earning a reputation for building well-organized communities, delivering high-quality construction, and developing modern lifestyle infrastructure focused on long-term value creation. Through this venture, Dr. Khan found that entrepreneurship served as a natural extension of leadership offering a practical avenue to transform visionary ideas into resilient institutions and abstract aspirations into tangible, real-world outcomes.

"Born into a legacy, but never lived in its shadow - he turned heritage into influence, influence into enterprise, and enterprise into a legacy of his own."



MAK PROJECTS - BUILDING WITH PURPOSE

MAK Projects represents one of the most important chapters in Dr. Khan's entrepreneurial journey. The company has developed its portfolio around the belief that premium living, thoughtful planning and responsible development can coexist. For Dr. Khan, real estate is not simply about constructing buildings. It is about understanding how people want to live, how cities evolve and how carefully planned environments can improve quality of life. This philosophy has shaped MAK Projects' approach to residential development, with emphasis on strategic locations, organised planning, internal infrastructure, landscaped surroundings, lifestyle amenities and long-term urban relevance.

CREATING COMMUNITIES, NOT JUST STRUCTURES

Projects such as MAK BTR and BTR Greens reflect this approach. MAK BTR represents one of the company's recognised development milestones, with its positioning within Hyderabad's southern growth corridor, organised gated planning, internal road networks, landscaped layouts and premium residential plotting environment. BTR Greens further developed this philosophy by creating a more lifestyle oriented residential environment. Its planning incorporates green surroundings, community infrastructure, open spaces and a clubhouse-oriented setting. Together, these developments reflect an effort to move beyond conventional construction and towards a more complete understanding of modern living. The objective is not simply to create a property, but to create an environment capable of retaining relevance as the city around it grows.

THE ENTREPRENEURIAL PHILOSOPHY

The evolution of MAK Projects reflects Dr. Khan's broader understanding of enterprise. Business, in his view, is not only about financial performance. It is also about creating trust, delivering quality and building something that can create value over the long term. This philosophy has encouraged MAK Projects to explore new ideas in architecture, residential planning, lifestyle infrastructure and sustainable construction. It is this willingness to evolve that connects Dr. Khan's entrepreneurial journey with his larger vision of responsible development.

CANADIAN WOOD VILLAS - SUSTAINABILITY MEETS LUXURY

One of the most distinctive projects associated with Dr. Khan's leadership is the Canadian Wood Villa at BTR Greens. Developed in collaboration with Canadian Wood, associated with Forestry Innovation Investment, a Crown agency of the Government of British Columbia, Canada, the project introduced sustainable wood-based construction into the premium residential segment. The initiative demonstrated how contemporary architecture and environmental responsibility could be brought together without compromising the idea of luxury living. The project used sustainably sourced timber from British Columbia and represented a forward-looking approach to residential construction. Instead of viewing sustainability as separate from premium development, the initiative explored how responsible materials could become part of the design itself.

BUILDING A LEGACY FOR THE FUTURE

Dr. Nawab Mir Nasir Ali Khan's journey stands as a powerful testament to how rich heritage and forward-looking vision can converge to shape a lasting legacy. From his roots in public responsibility and international diplomacy to his pioneering role with MAK Projects, his trajectory has been defined by a commitment to transforming ideas into institutions and aspirations into meaningful impact. With landmark developments like Fern Villas and Rosewood, he continues to redefine modern living by harmonizing luxury, sustainability, and human connectivity. Ultimately, Dr. Khan's story is about actively building a vibrant future where enterprise serves community and every milestone contributes to a legacy still dynamically in motion.



THE PRESIDENT'S TRAIN

From Royal Rails to a Modern Symbol of India

From the Vice-Regal Coach of colonial India to a modern symbol of the Republic, the Presidential Train has travelled across time connecting the highest constitutional office with the heart of the nation.

“

More than a mode of transport, it is a reminder that leadership is strongest when it stays connected with people, places and the journey of the nation.

”



A LEGACY ON TRACKS



75+ YEARS
of Presidential
rail journeys



1950 - TODAY
From Rajendra Prasad
to the modern Republic



7+ PRESIDENTS
have travelled on
special trains



A SYMBOL
of service, connection
and nationhood

A JOURNEY THROUGH TIME

COLONIAL ERA

The Vice-Regal Coach was used by the Victoria of India, reflecting the privileged travel of the colonial rule.

1950

A dedicated Presidential Salon was crafted in the 1950s. Dr. Rajendra Prasad used it for official journeys in 1956.

EARLY REPUBLIC

A significant colonial region in India, engaging with people and witnessing the nation's progress up close.

2003 & 2006

Dr. A. P. J. Abdul Kalam revived the tradition with journeys from Harnaut to Patna and Delhi to Dehradun.

2021

President Ram Nath Kovind travelled to Kanpur and his native village, reconnecting with his roots.

2025

President Droupadi Murmu continued the legacy with a special train journey to Uttarakhand and in September 2025.

INSIDE THE PRESIDENTIAL TRAIN

COMFORT & PRIVACY

- Spacious cabins, elegant lounges, conference areas, and modern interiors for a comfortable journey.

SECURITY & SAFETY

- Advanced security systems, surveillance and a fully secured composition for VVIP travel.

MODERN TECHNOLOGY

- Satellite communication, Wi-Fi, and state-of-the-art facilities to stay connected anywhere.

HERITAGE & DIGNITY

- A perfect blend of Indian craftsmanship, heritage design and modern engineering.

“

From royal rails to the heart of a Republic, the Presidential Train continues a timeless journey of service, connection and nationhood.

”

FROM HERITAGE TO HIGH-SPEED INDIA

There are trains that carry millions of passengers every day—and then there is the Presidential Train, a railway tradition that carries something far more significant: the story of India itself.

The tradition of presidential rail travel dates back to the colonial-era Vice-Regal Coach and evolved after Independence into a dedicated Presidential Saloon. For India's early Presidents, the railway was more than a means of transport. It offered a way to travel across a young Republic, connect with its people and remain close to the country beyond the capital. India's first President, Dr. Rajendra Prasad, became closely associated with rail journeys, and a dedicated Presidential Saloon completed in 1956 provided privacy, security and comfort for official travel. Presidents including Dr. S. Radhakrishnan, Dr. Zakir Husain, V. V. Giri and Neelam Sanjiva Reddy continued the tradition



The fascination with a Presidential Train lies not only in its appearance, but in the extraordinary environment created inside it. The historic Presidential Saloon was designed almost as a self-contained travelling residence, with a private bedroom, dining and conference space, lounge, kitchen and accommodation for accompanying staff. Later upgrades introduced modern communication and operational systems, reflecting the changing requirements of presidential travel.

That tradition took on a contemporary form on 25 September 2025, when President Droupadi Murmu travelled from New Delhi to Vrindavan by special train for her visit to Banke Bihari Temple, Nidhivan, Sudama Kutti, Kubja Krishna Mandir and Shri Krishna Janmasthan. The special formation used for the journey comprised 18 coaches, including 12 coaches of the Maharajas' Express with a Presidential Suite, Deluxe Suites, restaurants, lounges and power cars, along with additional coaches for senior railway personnel. Two locomotives were assigned to ensure operational reliability

But presidential rail travel is about much more than luxury. Behind the elegant interiors lies a carefully coordinated system of security, communications, medical support, hospitality, railway operations and protocol. Every aspect of the journey has to function seamlessly—from the railway station and route management to the President's movements at each destination.

WHEN THE PRESIDENT ARRIVES, A CITY PREPARES

A Presidential visit can also create a powerful ripple effect beyond the railway itself. When President Murmu visited Mathura-Vrindavan, preparations extended across roads, public spaces, railway surroundings and key locations on the presidential route. Security arrangements were intensified, while local authorities focused on ensuring that the city was clean, orderly and ready to receive the nation's highest constitutional office.

Yet it is important to distinguish visit-specific preparation from long-term development. The President's visit did not create Mathura-Vrindavan's transformation by itself. The region was already undergoing a much larger development programme. In August 2025, shortly before the visit, 118 projects worth approximately ₹646 crore were inaugurated or launched across Mathura-Vrindavan, covering areas including road infrastructure, pilgrimage-route beautification, water conservation, environmental protection and connectivity. A broader ₹30,000-crore development vision for the Braj region was also announced.

What the Presidential visit did was bring immediate national attention and an accelerated deadline to the places along her itinerary. It demonstrated how a high-profile constitutional visit can bring multiple agencies together, intensify civic preparation and place infrastructure under an unusually close spotlight.

WHAT'S INSIDE THE PRESIDENTIAL TRAIN?

The contrast is striking: the Presidential Train represents India's heritage, while Vande Bharat represents its momentum.

The Vande Bharat Express, introduced in 2019, became a powerful symbol of India's transition towards modern, indigenous railway technology bringing greater emphasis on speed, passenger comfort, contemporary interiors, safety and locally developed trainsets. What began with the New Delhi-Varanasi service has expanded into a growing network connecting cities and regions across the country.

Now the transformation is moving beyond passenger travel. In 2026, India's first Vande Bharat freight train entered high-speed trials, with testing reaching 145 kmph. The initiative points towards faster, more time-sensitive freight movement and a railway system increasingly positioned to strengthen logistics, supply chains and economic connectivity.

The Presidential Train and Vande Bharat may appear worlds apart, but together they tell one continuous story. One preserves the memory of a young Republic finding its identity; the other represents a nation building the technology to move faster into the future.

The coaches have changed. The technology has evolved. The cities along the tracks are transforming. But the journey continues.

From heritage to high speed, India's railway story is ultimately the story of a nation constantly moving forward.

STAR CASE OF THE WEEK



Management of Adult Short-Segment Hirschsprung's Disease by Per-Rectal Endoscopic Myotomy (PREM)

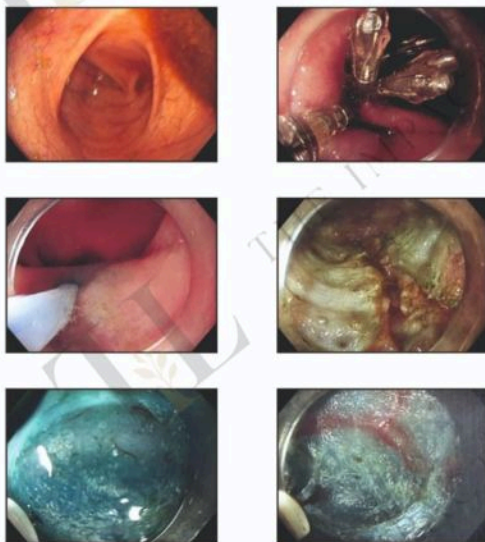
Case Study | Department of Medical Gastroenterology
STAR Hospitals, Nanakramguda

A 25-year-old woman presented with constipation from infancy, with **bowel evacuation** once **every 7-10 days** despite high dose laxative use.

Diagnosis:



High-resolution anorectal manometry showed **absence of the rectoanal inhibitory reflex (RAIR)**. Rectal contrast study showed **narrowing of the rectum** and **rectosigmoid, sigmoid dilatation, reversal of the rectosigmoid ratio**, and a transition zone. Colonoscopic deep submucosal suction biopsies using an **EVL-assisted banding technique** and multiple resection biopsies demonstrated an **aganglionic segment of 10 cm from the dentate line**, confirming **short-segment Hirschsprung's disease**.



PER RECTAL ENDOSCOPIC MYOTOMY

Treatment:

A **Per-Rectal Endoscopic Myotomy (PREM)** was performed through a posterior-wall mucosal incision. A submucosal tunnel was created across the transition zone. Circular myotomy extended from **1 cm proximal to the dentate line to 10 cm** proximally, including 2 cm above the transition zone, to divide the muscle in the aganglionic segment. The mucosal entry was closed with endoscopic clips, and haemostasis was maintained.

Capnothorax and pneumothorax occurred after the procedure and were managed with **bilateral intercostal chest tube drainage**. Rectal contrast CT and check sigmoidoscopy showed **no leak**. A **liquid diet was started**, chest drains were removed and the patient was discharged on day 5. At follow-up, the **patient passed two formed stools per day without laxatives**, compared with one bowel movement every 7-10 days before treatment.

Treating Team:



Dr. Abhiram Koganti
Senior Consultant -
Medical Gastroenterology
& Hepatology



Dr. Sarath Chandra G
Senior Consultant-
Medical Gastroenterology
& Hepatology



Dr. Y Rami Reddy
Senior Consultant & Head -
Interventional & Therapeutic
Gastroenterology



Dr. Kondal Reddy Mogili
Consultant -
Medical Gastroenterology

Per-Rectal Endoscopic Myotomy (PREM) can treat short-segment Hirschsprung's disease in children and adults. Endotracheal intubation with controlled ventilation before PREM may reduce the risk of CO₂-related barotrauma and pneumothorax during third-space tunnelling and has been incorporated into the institutional protocol.

Beyond the Harvest: Building Rural Enterprises

Agriculture is often viewed simply as the process of growing food. But for Agrighar, agriculture represents something much larger an ecosystem of livelihoods, entrepreneurship, technology, food processing and rural development. Established in 2019, Agrighar Services Pvt. Ltd. was founded with a clear belief: farmers should not remain only producers of raw commodities; they should also have the opportunity to participate in the value created from what they produce. Agrighar's main aim is to serve as a one-stop solution platform connecting all stakeholders across the agriculture value chain, with a strong focus on the soil-to-shelf, farm-to-fork and root-to-retail concepts. This vision forms the foundation of its work to create an ecosystem where farmers, FPOs, women, rural youth and agri-entrepreneurs can access knowledge, technology, infrastructure, markets and enterprise support. Its long-term ambition is to contribute to creating one lakh rural livelihoods in agriculture and allied sectors within a decade, while strengthening rural resilience and reducing distress-driven migration.

Beyond Producing, Towards Creating Value

Agrighar emerged from a concern surrounding one of agriculture's fundamental challenges. A farmer may spend months cultivating millet, pulses, fruits, vegetables or grains, yet a significant part of the final value can be captured by other stages of the value chain. Limited access to scientific storage, processing, packaging, branding and direct markets can restrict economic opportunities for producers. At the same time, agricultural produce can be lost between harvest and consumption due to gaps in post-harvest management, storage, transportation and processing. Agrighar's response is to bridge these gaps by connecting production with processing, knowledge with implementation, innovation with entrepreneurship, and farmers with markets.



From Farm to Value.

From Value to Enterprise.

From Enterprise to Livelihood.

From Livelihood to a Stronger Rural Economy.



This approach has gradually shaped Agrighar into an organisation that looks beyond individual interventions. Its model connects multiple stages of the rural enterprise journey: training, infrastructure, processing, entrepreneurship, market access and incubation. The organisation's experience has reinforced the idea that rural transformation cannot be achieved through training alone. Knowledge becomes more powerful when entrepreneurs can access the infrastructure, technology, finance and markets required to turn that knowledge into viable businesses.

Building Rural Enterprises

A major part of Agrighar's work focuses on rural agripreneurship and incubation. The organisation works with rural youth, women, farmers and FPOs to identify opportunities across agriculture and allied sectors and develop them into viable enterprises. Its work extends into food processing and community food-processing clusters, enabling agricultural produce to be processed closer to where it is produced. Its integrated training-cum-multi-food-processing facility at Choutuppal, Telangana, brings training, food processing and enterprise development together. Agrighar has also expanded into post-harvest solutions, FPO capacity building, food-product development, Manufacturing as a Service (MAAS), and agripreneurship programmes.

MEET DR. SOWMINI SUNKARA
MANAGING DIRECTOR,
AGRIGHAR, WEAIM & WEMART





Post-harvest management is another important part of this ecosystem. Through solutions involving dry and cold storage, solar dehydration and improved storage technologies, Agrighar seeks to reduce avoidable losses and extend the economic life of agricultural produce. Its MAAS model also enables entrepreneurs, FPOs and emerging food businesses to access processing, packaging, white-labelling and related manufacturing capabilities without having to independently establish every component of the required infrastructure. For FPOs, the focus is not simply on aggregation. Agrighar works towards helping them move towards value addition, processing, branding and market-oriented enterprises. This represents a broader shift - from treating farmers primarily as suppliers of raw material to enabling them to become participants in businesses built around their own produce.

People at the Centre of the Value Chain

Agrighar's work reaches farmers, FPOs, women and SHG members, rural youth, agri-entrepreneurs, tribal communities, rural MSMEs and food-processing entrepreneurs. It helps these groups move further along the value chain through access to skills, enterprise opportunities, markets and infrastructure. Agrighar also creates awareness about government schemes and grants, connecting eligible beneficiaries to relevant support and resources. Its impact goes beyond training, focusing on income, employment, enterprise development, market access and food security.

For example, a farmer who once sold raw produce can become part of an FPO that aggregates, processes, packages and markets that produce. Similarly, a rural woman can progress from wage work to becoming a processor, entrepreneur, producer, brand owner or service provider. At Choutuppal, Agrighar connects training with infrastructure, product development, processing, packaging, branding and market opportunities. The larger objective is to move from "training people for jobs" to "training people to create enterprises and jobs," supported by the right schemes, grants and ecosystem resources.

"True rural transformation begins when communities are not merely given opportunities, but empowered to create, own and sustain them."

Technology with a Purpose

For Agrighar, technology is not an end in itself but a tool to make rural entrepreneurship more accessible, affordable and scalable. The organisation uses digital tools for assessments, data collection, monitoring, management information systems, dashboards, enterprise incubation, knowledge dissemination, market linkage and data-driven decision-making, while also exploring solutions such as solar dehydration, improved storage and decentralised food-processing systems. At the same time, Agrighar recognises that digital tools cannot replace essential physical infrastructure. Its practical philosophy is simple: use digital solutions where they work, physical infrastructure where it is essential, and integrate both where they are needed together.

Building Sustainable Rural Ecosystems

Agrighar focuses on creating locally owned, economically viable and self-sustaining rural ecosystems rather than short-term interventions. By developing entrepreneurs, strengthening FPOs, enabling value addition, building market linkages and promoting resource-efficient technologies, it helps communities move towards enterprise-led growth. Its impact is strengthened through partnerships with government, corporates, financial institutions, research organisations, NGOs and entrepreneurs, combining resources, technology, knowledge and market access. Through this collaborative model, Agrighar aims to improve farmer incomes, rural employment, women's entrepreneurship, post-harvest management and local enterprise development, making communities active participants in their economic progress.

A Larger Vision for Rural India

Agrighar's vision is to build a stronger rural economy through agripreneurship, food-processing clusters, FPO enterprises, women and youth entrepreneurship, post-harvest solutions and digital innovation. We aim to be changemakers by inviting CSR companies to sponsor and support rural agriculture development projects as an integrated ecosystem. Through partnerships connecting farmers, enterprises, finance, technology and markets, Agrighar seeks to create sustainable economic opportunities for rural communities, both in India and globally.



WHERE THE RIVER MEETS RESILIENCE

Assam's enduring struggle with floods, erosion and the people who refuse to stop rebuilding

By The Impact Ledger | August 2026

Every year, when the monsoon clouds gather over Assam, the rivers begin to rise. For a state shaped by water, this is both familiar and frightening. The Brahmaputra, the Barak and their many tributaries have sustained Assam for generations, feeding its fields, shaping its settlements and supporting livelihoods. But when the waters rise beyond their banks, the same rivers can quickly become a force of destruction. Flooding is not an occasional event in Assam; it is a recurring part of life. The Government of Assam identifies nearly 39.58% of the state's geographical area as flood-prone, while an average of around 9.31 lakh hectares is affected by floods every year. Yet the story of Assam's floods cannot be told only through numbers. It has to be told through people – families carrying their belongings through floodwater, farmers watching their fields disappear, children waiting for their schools to reopen, boatmen helping strangers reach safety and volunteers arriving with food, medicines, books and cleaning equipment. Behind every flood is another story: the story of people coming together.

A State Shaped by Water

Assam's geography explains much of its vulnerability. The state is shaped by the Brahmaputra and Barak valleys, surrounded by hills and connected by a vast network of rivers and tributaries. During the monsoon, intense rainfall across Assam and neighbouring hill regions sends enormous quantities of water downstream. The Brahmaputra is one of the region's dynamic rivers, with shifting channels, eroding banks and constantly moving sediment. Sandbars appear and disappear, while villages and farmland remain exposed to the river. This makes flood management more complicated than simply building barriers. Assam's flood challenge combines rainfall, upstream runoff, sedimentation, erosion, drainage and changing river morphology. For communities living beside these waterways, uncertainty becomes part of everyday life.

The 2026 Floods: Another Difficult Chapter

The 2026 monsoon has once again demonstrated the scale of Assam's vulnerability. Repeated spells of heavy and extremely heavy rainfall across Upper Assam and neighbouring hill catchments created successive waves of flooding. Runoff from regions including Arunachal Pradesh and Nagaland contributed to rapidly rising water levels in parts of Upper Assam. By August 15, reports citing the Assam State Disaster Management Authority placed the flood-related death toll at 104, while more than 78,000 people had been affected across seven districts during the latest phase of flooding. But statistics cannot fully capture what those days looked like on the ground. In some communities, floodwater rose to eight or ten feet. Roads became waterways, houses were submerged and families were forced to leave behind the places they had spent years building. In some areas, the destruction was so severe that there was barely a home left to return to.

When the Flood Took Everything

The floods that struck Assam on July 19 brought the scale of destruction into sharp focus. Entire villages were affected, homes were submerged and schools that once stood at the centre of local communities were left underwater. In Nepali Kutti, an entire village was washed away, taking its school with it. Across Sivasagar and other affected areas, several government schools, colleges and educational institutions were submerged. For children, losing a school was about more than losing a building. Books, school bags and study materials were destroyed, classes were interrupted and examination preparations were thrown into uncertainty. When the water receded, the damage remained. Floors were covered with mud and silt, furniture was damaged and debris filled classrooms and homes. Restoring these spaces became an enormous task that government resources alone could not immediately handle.

On the Ground, People Stepped Forward

This was when the response began to take on a deeply human character. As the scale of the disaster became visible, volunteers and organisations started arriving on the ground, not simply to distribute immediate relief but to help communities begin the difficult work of recovery. Relief teams from Punjab and other parts of India joined local volunteers. Organisations such as Global Sikh, Khalsa Aid, Hemkunt Foundation and Saskan Foundation worked alongside the Sikh Youth Association, All Assam Sikh Youth Association and volunteers connected with local gurdwaras. Their work was practical and immediate. They helped clear mud and silt from homes and educational institutions, supported families with essential supplies and worked alongside local communities to make damaged spaces usable again. In the aftermath of a flood, these tasks may seem ordinary, but for a family standing in a home filled with mud and debris, someone arriving to help clean can mean the beginning of recovery.

A Gurdwara That Kept Serving

One of the most striking examples of community resilience came from the Sivasagar Gurdwara. Even after the gurdwara itself was affected by the floods, its doors remained open to people in need. For more than a month, food was prepared and distributed to around 5,000 people. The effort showed that humanitarian work does not always come from distant organisations with large resources. Sometimes it comes from a local institution that is facing the same disaster but still chooses to serve others. Volunteers continued preparing and distributing food while families around them struggled to find shelter and basic necessities. The gurdwara became more than a place of worship during those difficult weeks; it became a place of support, food and hope.

Young People Rebuilding Education

Education quickly emerged as another important part of the recovery effort. Local young people stepped forward to collect and distribute school supplies, including books, pens and school bags, so that children could gradually return to their studies. Their contribution may appear small compared with the scale of the flood, but for a child who has lost books, belongings and a sense of routine, receiving a new school bag or a set of notebooks can be deeply meaningful. It sends a simple message: the disaster has interrupted your education, but it does not have to end it. The Assam government also began considering measures to support students whose education had been disrupted, particularly with matriculation and Higher Secondary examinations approaching. Rebuilding schools, therefore, became part of rebuilding lives.

In Assam, relief is more than immediate assistance it is a lifeline for families facing uncertainty, helping them recover, rebuild, and hope for a better tomorrow.



The Silent Destruction of Erosion

Floodwater is the most visible face of Assam's river problem, but erosion can be slower and equally devastating. As the Brahmaputra and its tributaries change their course, sections of riverbank gradually disappear. Agricultural land, homes, roads and entire settlements can be lost. According to the Assam Water Resources Department, more than 4.27 lakh hectares of land have been eroded by rivers since 1950, with an estimated average annual erosion of around 8,000 hectares. For a family losing land to the river, the loss is not simply financial. Land can represent a home, a livelihood, family history and a sense of belonging. When that land disappears into the river, rebuilding may mean finding another place to live and a new way to earn. Majuli, the famous river island of Assam, remains one of the most visible symbols of this struggle between land and water.



"Across Assam, families are struggling to rebuild their lives, facing uncertainty, loss, and the everyday challenge of simply getting by."

Assam Rises Again

Assam's floods are not only a story of rising rivers, damaged homes and lost livelihoods; they are also a story of people standing together when everything around them is uncertain. From volunteers clearing mud from schools to young people collecting books, community kitchens feeding thousands and local groups helping families rebuild, the strongest response has often come from people themselves.

The Brahmaputra will continue to shape Assam, and floods will remain part of its reality. But every repaired home, reopened classroom and helping hand shows that resilience can be stronger than destruction.



"THE RIVER MAY TEST ASSAM EVERY YEAR, BUT ITS PEOPLE CONTINUE TO PROVE THAT AFTER EVERY FLOOD, ASSAM CAN RISE AGAIN."

THE MAN WHO MADE THE RULEBOOK WALK

Tukaram Mundhe's uncompromising journey from a farmer's son to Maharashtra's most talked-about food safety officer

There are officers who occupy a chair, and then there are officers who make the chair uncomfortable. Tukaram Mundhe belongs to the second kind. Born into a farming family in Tadsonna village in Maharashtra's Beed district, Mundhe's early life was far removed from the corridors of power. He studied at a Zilla Parishad school before pursuing higher education and eventually clearing the UPSC Civil Services Examination in 2004 with an All India Rank of 20. He joined the 2005 batch of the Indian Administrative Service in the Maharashtra cadre, beginning a journey that would take him through some of the state's most challenging administrative assignments. But his story was never simply about reaching the IAS. It was about what he chose to do once he got there. Over the years, Mundhe developed a reputation for approaching public administration with unusual directness. For him, rules were not meant to sit quietly inside government files; they were meant to reach the streets, offices, businesses and communities they were created to protect.

A CAREER MEASURED IN TRANSFERS

For most civil servants, frequent transfers are viewed as professional disruption. For Tukaram Mundhe, they became almost a defining feature of his career. Over approximately 21 years of service, he has reportedly been transferred around 25 times, with several postings becoming associated with clashes involving political establishments, powerful interests and local systems. Supporters interpret his frequent transfers as the price of refusing to compromise, while critics have questioned his uncompromising and sometimes confrontational style.

Yet the number itself tells a remarkable story. Mundhe continued to return to public administration with the same reputation that had followed him from one posting to another. Somewhere along the way, he became known as "Singham" and was compared by sections of the public to the determined administrator portrayed in Nayak. The nickname may sound cinematic, but the reason behind it is distinctly real: an officer who appears more comfortable confronting a difficult system than quietly becoming part of it.

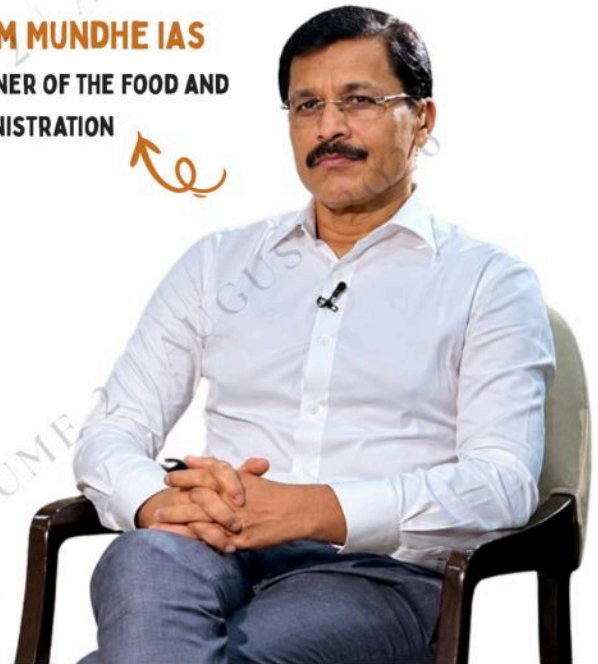
WHEN THE "SINGHAM" ENTERED THE KITCHEN

In May 2026, Mundhe took charge as Commissioner of Maharashtra's Food and Drug Administration, and his latest chapter began in an unexpected battlefield the kitchen. Restaurants, food outlets, hotels, commercial kitchens, storage facilities and food businesses became the new focus of an intensified enforcement drive. Establishments have faced enforcement action, including licence suspensions.

MEET

TUKARAM MUNDHE IAS

COMMISSIONER OF THE FOOD AND DRUG ADMINISTRATION



What makes the campaign striking is its simplicity: food safety is not being treated merely as paperwork. It is being brought into the public eye. A refrigerator, a storage room or a cooking counter can become evidence of whether a business genuinely respects the people it serves. Mundhe's approach has effectively taken the rulebook out of the office and placed it where it matters most between the kitchen and the customer's plate.

NO VIP LANE IN THE RULEBOOK

The campaign became even more visible when it reached Bollywood. The Maharashtra FDA issued show-cause notices to Shah Rukh Khan, Ajay Devgn and Tiger Shroff over advertisements for Vimal Elaichi, raising concerns about alleged surrogate promotion associated with pan masala and tobacco products. The notices generated national attention because the names involved were among the biggest in Indian cinema.

But beneath the celebrity headlines was a larger question: Does influence come with responsibility? Mundhe has maintained that the action was based on regulatory concerns rather than any personal campaign against celebrities. That makes the episode particularly significant. The issue was not simply about who appeared in an advertisement; it was about the responsibility that comes with using public influence. In Mundhe's world, the rulebook does not appear to have a celebrity entrance, a political entrance or a VIP entrance. There is only one entrance and everyone is expected to walk through it. This even-handed approach sent a clear message that brand endorsements would no longer serve as a shield against public accountability. By holding high-profile figures to the exact same standards as local business owners, the agency underscored that regulatory compliance applies equally to everyone, regardless of stardom.



"MORE TRANSFERS MEAN MORE OPPORTUNITIES EVERY NEW POSTING BRINGS A NEW CHALLENGE I SEE IT AS ANOTHER CHANCE TO MAKE A DIFFERENCE. MY FOCUS REMAINS ON DOING MY WORK WITH HONESTY"

— TUKARAM MUNDHE IAS

THE FACE OF AN UNCOMFORTABLE QUESTION

Mundhe has become an unusual kind of public figure a bureaucrat whose name is recognised far beyond government circles. His inspections are discussed, his transfers are remembered and his uncompromising image continues to attract public attention. Yet he has resisted being reduced to the celebrity label attached to him, describing himself as a food safety commissioner doing his job. Perhaps that is precisely what makes the story compelling. He did not become visible by seeking the spotlight; he became visible because his work repeatedly brought difficult questions into the spotlight.

What happens when rules are ignored? Who is responsible when public safety is compromised? And how much should an ordinary citizen have to worry about something as basic as the food they eat? These questions transform Mundhe from merely an officer into a symbol of a larger conversation about accountability.

BEYOND THE PLATE

Food safety can sound like a technical subject filled with licences, inspections, samples, laboratories and regulations. But behind every one of those words is a person. It is the child eating a school meal, the family ordering dinner, the worker buying lunch between shifts, the parent purchasing milk or the elderly customer trusting a packaged product. For them, food safety is not a government file it is personal. One contaminated ingredient can become a medical emergency; one unhygienic kitchen can potentially affect hundreds of customers. That is why the work of a food regulator carries a responsibility far greater than simply identifying violations.

The real purpose is to protect the invisible trust between the person who prepares food and the person who eats it. Mundhe's current campaign has brought that trust into focus, reminding businesses that every plate carries a responsibility that cannot be seen on a menu.

THE MAN WHO REFUSED TO BECOME COMFORTABLE

Perhaps the most fascinating part of Tukaram Mundhe's journey is that his reputation was not created by one dramatic incident. It was built gradually posting after posting, transfer after transfer, confrontation after confrontation and, now, inspection after inspection. Around 25 transfers could have become nothing more than a statistic in a service record. Instead, they became part of his public identity. The "Singham" nickname could have remained a social-media description. Instead, it became shorthand for an administrative style. His current food-safety campaign could have been another government enforcement exercise. Instead, it has become a public conversation. That is what happens when an officer's personality becomes inseparable from the way he interprets responsibility. **He has repeatedly demonstrated that administrative power means little unless it is accompanied by the willingness to use it.**

THE REAL "SINGHAM" EFFECT

India's real challenge isn't a lack of rules, but ensuring their enforcement. Tukaram Mundhe's career has elevated conversations around governance and accountability, yet the true test of his FDA tenure lies beyond initial headlines it rests on whether food businesses permanently adopt safer, cleaner, and more responsible practices.

THE REAL "SINGHAM" EFFECT

Tukaram Mundhe's story is not ultimately about an IAS officer with a long list of postings or a commissioner leading a crackdown. It is about a man who has built an unusual career around refusing to become comfortable with compromise. From a village in Beed to the highest levels of state administration, his journey has repeatedly placed him in situations where rules and resistance meet. Today, his workplace may be the restaurant kitchen, the food warehouse or the inspection site, but the larger principle remains unchanged. A rule is only as strong as the person willing to enforce it. Perhaps that is why the "Singham" label continues to follow him. Not because he is a movie hero, but because he has made something that usually lives inside government files suddenly visible in everyday life. **He has made the rulebook walk to the streets, into the kitchens and, ultimately, right up to the plate.**

COCKROACH JANTA PARTY

HOW AN INTERNET JOKE BECAME A VOICE FOR YOUTH DISCONTENT

What began as an unusual response to a controversial remark quickly became one of the most talked-about youth movements on Indian social media in 2026. The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) was founded by Abhijeet Dipke, a 30-year-old Boston University graduate, after remarks by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant during a court hearing triggered anger among sections of young Indians. The remarks referred to unemployed young people who entered professions such as journalism and activism as “cockroaches” and “parasites”. Dipke responded by turning the word into the identity of a satirical political movement.

FROM A REMARK TO A MOVEMENT

The idea was initially simple: reclaim an insult through humour. Dipke created an online platform and invited young people who felt ignored, frustrated or misrepresented to identify themselves with the unlikely symbol of a cockroach. What could have remained an internet joke quickly gathered momentum. Within days, the movement attracted a huge following across social media, with young Indians using memes, posts and videos to express their frustration about employment, education, examinations and political accountability.

The name itself was part of the satire. “Cockroach Janta Party” deliberately echoes the naming style of established political parties while turning an ordinary insult into a political identity. Instead of hiding from the label, supporters embraced it. The movement’s appeal came partly from this reversal: something intended as dismissive was transformed into a symbol of persistence.



ABHIJEET DIPKE

FOUNDER,
COCKROACH
JANTA PARTY



They called us cockroaches.
We decided to organise.
They ignored us.
We became a movement.



YOUTH IDENTITY BEYOND TRADITIONAL POLITICS

One of the most striking aspects of the Cockroach Janta Party was the way it challenged conventional ideas of political participation. Many of the young people engaging with CJP were not necessarily members of political organisations, nor did they come from established activist networks. Their participation began through everyday digital behaviour: sharing a post, reacting to a meme, commenting on an issue or joining an online discussion.

This gave the movement a distinctly informal character. Political expression no longer required a party office, membership card or organised rally. A smartphone and a social-media account were enough to enter the conversation. Humour lowered the barrier to participation, allowing serious concerns to be discussed in a format that felt familiar to younger audiences.



WHEN HUMOUR BECAME POLITICAL

The movement's growth revealed that the humour was carrying a more serious message underneath. For many young people, the CJP became a space to talk about problems that extended well beyond the original controversy. Employment opportunities, examination-related concerns, education, rising economic pressures, corruption, institutional accountability and the feeling of being unheard became part of the wider conversation surrounding the movement. This is what made CJP different from an ordinary viral meme. It connected entertainment with political expression. A generation comfortable with memes, short videos and social-media debates found a language that felt closer to its own culture than conventional political speeches. The movement demonstrated how quickly digital platforms can turn an individual reaction into a collective conversation.

FROM ONLINE SPACE TO THE STREETS

As its following grew, CJP moved beyond social media and began organising public protests. Its activities increasingly focused on demands involving employment, education, transparency, press freedom and institutional accountability. The movement's protests at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi became a significant part of its public identity, with supporters gathering under the unusual cockroach symbol to draw attention to their demands. The transition from online satire to physical protest was important. It showed that digital activism can sometimes move beyond screens when people find common concerns around which to organize. The movement also attracted attention from political figures and public personalities, further increasing its visibility. At the same time, its rapid rise brought scrutiny over its political affiliations, leadership and future direction.

THE NEET CONNECTION

Concerns over NEET and alleged paper leaks brought examination fairness into the political spotlight. With millions of students affected by competitive exams, CJP used the issue to demand greater accountability and action on education. The campaign showed how online movements can turn student concerns into wider political conversations. For many young people, the issue represented not just an examination problem

THE POWER OF A SYMBOL

The cockroach became more than a provocative name for CJP. It developed into a visual identity that could be recognised instantly across digital platforms, posters and public gatherings. Its unconventional nature helped the movement stand apart from traditional political imagery built around familiar colours, personalities and party symbols. Supporters used the cockroach creatively in illustrations, memes, merchandise and protest material, giving the movement a distinct visual language. This consistency made CJP easier to recognise and share, particularly among younger audiences. More importantly, the symbol demonstrated how modern movements can build identity without relying entirely on prominent leaders. In CJP's case, an unusual visual became a tool for visibility, community and collective expression.



AN UNUSUAL FORM OF YOUTH POLITICS

CJP's biggest development came when its campaign moved beyond social media and into wider political debate. Its protests brought education, examination fairness and accountability into focus, with the movement claiming a role in the pressure that preceded the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan. Beyond political outcomes, CJP's significance lies in its new language of youth protest. It turned frustration into humour, humour into identity, and online engagement into public action. While questions remain about its long-term political influence, its journey from a courtroom remark to a recognised movement shows how memes and digital communities can become powerful tools of political expression.

"CJP's leadership emerged from a new generation of digital voices informal, bold and unconventional, turning online frustration into collective action and giving young citizens a platform to be heard."



NAARI MANI COLLECTIVE

Discover. Develop. Decide.

*Empowered women,
empower communities.*

BUILDING CONFIDENCE, CREATING POSSIBILITIES

Education can open doors, but confidence, guidance, and opportunity help young women step through them. Naari Mani Collective was founded on the belief that academic achievement alone does not guarantee empowerment. Many young women, particularly first-generation learners, need access to mentors, role models, life skills, and supportive spaces to turn their education into independence. The organisation works primarily with young women aged 15-21, helping them discover their strengths, develop confidence, and make informed decisions about education, careers, and life. Its approach is built around the Confidence Pipeline - Discover, Develop, and Decide.

BREAKING BARRIERS BEFORE CRISIS

Founded by Divya Menon D., a law student from Kerala, Naari Mani Collective was created in response to the quiet limitations that social and patriarchal expectations can place on girls. Rather than intervening only after a crisis has occurred, the organisation focuses on prevention, reaching young people while their confidence, ambitions, and understanding of their possibilities are still developing. This makes its approach different from conventional crisis-focused interventions. The Collective aims to create an environment where girls can question stereotypes, express themselves freely, explore careers, and see examples of women achieving beyond traditional expectations. Through conversations, mentorship, and community engagement, it encourages young girls to recognise their own agency and make informed choices about their futures. Its work ultimately seeks to build a generation that is more confident, aware, and willing to challenge the boundaries placed before them.



Discover. Develop. Decide.

The philosophy of the Collective is captured in three powerful words.

DISCOVER

Opening young women to possibilities they may never have encountered begins with expanding their horizons beyond traditional expectations. By introducing them to diverse fields, varied career paths, and inspiring role models, they are encouraged to see beyond immediate societal limitations. This initial spark helps them recognize the strengths, talents, and potential they already possess, setting the stage for self-belief to take root.

DEVELOP

Building confidence is a continuous process cultivated through mentorship, practical life skills, and open, meaningful conversations. Providing structured guidance and interactive learning environments allows young women to build resilience, hone their communication skills, and critically evaluate the world around them. As awareness deepens, they learn to articulate their thoughts, navigate challenges with assurance, and trust in their personal capabilities.

DECIDE

True empowerment culminates in autonomy giving women the information, resources, and support needed to make independent choices about their education, careers, health, and futures. When equipped with knowledge and backed by a supportive community, they step comfortably into leadership roles within their own lives. They transform from passive participants into decisive architects of their own destinies, creating lasting change for themselves and their communities.



FROM SCHOOL SESSIONS TO COMMUNITY OUTREACH

The organisation's early journey has been shaped by sessions, partnerships, and community engagement. Its first Discovery Sessions were conducted at Zilla Parishad High School and Sree Chaitanya School in Maharajpet, Telangana, involving students from Classes 6 to 9. These sessions introduced conversations around gender equality and breaking stereotypes. The work later expanded into menstrual health, hygiene, and awareness, while a partnership with the Legal Aid Club of ICFAI Law School, Hyderabad, enabled direct conversations with women in Jhansi Lingapur village. This marked an important step from school-based awareness towards grassroots engagement. Building on this foundation, the initiative continued to scale its impact by integrating legal literacy and health advocacy into rural outreach programs.

THE CONFIDENCE PIPELINE

At the centre of Naari Mani Collective is a broader ecosystem combining mentorship and guidance, life skills and confidence, holistic wellbeing, career exploration, and a pilot programme focused on self-discovery. The objective goes beyond delivering information. Through communication, goal-setting, leadership, emotional resilience, career exposure, and interaction with professionals, the organisation seeks to help young women understand their strengths and develop the confidence to make their own choices.

TURNING HESITATION INTO CONFIDENCE

One of the organisation's most significant early experiences came through its first Discovery Session at Zilla Parishad High School. What began as a conversation about gender equality and stereotypes gradually developed into active participation. Students began sharing their opinions, asking questions, and exploring perspectives they had not previously considered. A second session at Sree Chaitanya School reflected the same spirit of curiosity and confidence. Students also received welfare kits supported by the organisation's first individual sponsor. These sessions became the foundation for further health and hygiene programmes and community outreach. Building on this momentum, the team expanded its interactive workshops to cover essential life skills and personal safety, encouraging students to voice their ideas without hesitation. Local teachers actively collaborated to ensure that the open dialogues continued long after the sessions concluded. This combined approach of structural education and tangible support established a sustainable model for the organization's future youth engagement.



BUILDING CONFIDENCE, CREATING POSSIBILITIES

Naari Mani Collective believes that impact is measured not only by the number of people reached, but also by the confidence with which participants engage, question, and express themselves. Its sessions have seen a shift from hesitation towards open dialogue, particularly around topics that may not always have a comfortable space for discussion. While the organisation currently uses qualitative and observational methods to understand this change, it is working towards structured post-session surveys and follow-up systems to track longer-term outcomes. Partnerships have also been central to its growth, with individual supporters contributing to early student kits and institutional collaborations, such as the Legal Aid Club, supporting community outreach. The Collective sees partnerships as a way to bring together expertise, mentorship, networks, technology, and resources while retaining its grassroots, dialogue-driven approach. Its future plans include building stronger mentorship pathways, creating more opportunities for career exposure, and reaching young women who may have limited access to professional networks. By connecting lived experiences with practical guidance, the organisation hopes to help participants move from awareness to action. It also aims to build a wider community of women and allies who can contribute knowledge, encouragement, and opportunities. Through these efforts, the Collective seeks to make empowerment a sustained process rather than a one-time intervention. Its larger vision is to show that empowerment can begin before a crisis by creating spaces where young women can question limitations, recognise their abilities, explore possibilities, and make informed decisions for themselves.

A CALL TO CONTRIBUTE

Naari Mani Collective believes that meaningful change does not always begin with significant resources it begins with the willingness to listen, understand, and act. Volunteering time, sharing knowledge and skills, creating opportunities, supporting responsible initiatives, and engaging with communities can each become valuable contributions towards lasting impact. The organisation encourages individuals, institutions, professionals, and communities to look beyond traditional forms of support and recognise the power of collaboration, mentorship, and meaningful conversations. When diverse people come together with a shared commitment to creating opportunity and challenging limitations, even a single conversation can influence a perspective, inspire confidence, and open a new path. For Naari Mani Collective, contribution is not simply about giving; it is about standing alongside communities and helping create the conditions in which young people can shape their own futures. Every effort, however small, can become part of a larger movement towards a more confident and equitable society.

"True empowerment begins when a woman is no longer simply given a voice, but is trusted to use it to question what exists, challenge what holds her back, choose her own path, and shape the future she wants to see. When one woman finds the courage to speak, she may change her own life; when many women find that courage together, they can transform an entire community."

Amplifying Stories That Matter

Powered by Touch-A-Life Foundation

Every day, nonprofits, CSR teams, changemakers, professionals and young people are creating meaningful impact in communities. TALRadio exists to give these voices a wider platform.



TALRadio is a multilingual kindness radio and social-impact media platform creating content in five languages.



It is a pro bono media platform that showcases meaningful work from nonprofits, changemakers, CSR teams, healthcare professionals, educators, innovators and community leaders.



Anyone, anywhere can access TALRadio through the app, podcasts, YouTube, social media and blogs.



TALRadio Youth Clubs are active in schools and colleges, with 12 clubs already started, helping students build social advocacy, communication, leadership and community engagement skills.



TALRadio naturally supports the broader goals of social development and collaboration.



5

Languages



Pro Bono
Media Platform



Nonprofits | CSR |
Changemakers



App | Podcasts | YouTube |
Social Media | Blogs



12

Youth Clubs

“ **Meaningful work deserves meaningful visibility.** ”

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EMPOWERING THE GENERATION THAT WILL SHAPE *Tomorrow*

Youth has never been just about age. It represents energy, curiosity, ambition and the courage to imagine a world that can be better than the one we know today.

Every year on August 12, International Youth Day provides an opportunity to recognise the ideas and contributions of young people and to reflect on the opportunities, challenges and responsibilities that come with being part of a rapidly changing generation. Across the world, young people are stepping beyond traditional boundaries, using education, technology, creativity and community action to influence the world around them. They are not simply preparing to inherit the future; in many ways, they are already helping to shape it.



Young people are influencing the way societies communicate, work, innovate and respond to challenges.



They are starting businesses, creating technologies, volunteering, pursuing research and participating in public life.



They use their voices to bring attention to issues that matter and build a better world for everyone.



They are not just the future leaders of tomorrow; they are the active changemakers of today.

A GENERATION WITH A VOICE

Young people today have more opportunities than ever to learn, connect and express themselves. Digital platforms have given them a powerful space to share ideas, raise awareness, build communities and participate in conversations that shape society. A student, creator or young entrepreneur can reach thousands of people with little more than a smartphone and a meaningful idea. This generation is using its digital voice not only for self-expression but also to support causes, question existing systems and bring attention to issues that may otherwise go unnoticed. Their ability to connect across boundaries is creating new forms of youth participation and opening the door to a more engaged and informed society. With creativity and confidence, young voices are challenging traditional ways of communication and redefining how change begins. Their ideas, when translated into meaningful action, have the potential to influence communities and shape the future.

A GENERATION WITH A VOICE

With greater digital influence comes greater responsibility. Young people must learn to navigate misinformation, recognise unreliable sources and think critically before accepting or sharing information. Protecting personal privacy, maintaining healthy digital habits and understanding the impact of online actions are equally important in an increasingly connected world. Responsible digital participation means using technology with awareness, purpose and respect. When young people choose to use their platforms thoughtfully, they can transform social media from a space of passive consumption into a powerful tool for learning, collaboration, awareness and positive change. By making informed choices online, they can encourage healthier digital communities and inspire others to use technology constructively. In the digital age, responsible voices can turn influence into meaningful impact.



Happy
**INTERNATIONAL
YOUTH DAY!**

AUGUST 12

Beyond Classrooms and Degrees

Education remains one of the strongest foundations of youth development, but the meaning of education is changing. A degree can open a door, but the skills needed to succeed in today's world extend far beyond academic qualifications. Communication, creativity, critical thinking, teamwork, digital literacy, problem-solving and adaptability have become equally important.

The transition from education to employment is one of the most important stages in a young person's life. Internships, apprenticeships, vocational training, mentorship programmes and practical exposure can help students understand how their knowledge applies outside the classroom. For a young person from a financially disadvantaged background, one opportunity can sometimes change the direction of an entire life. A scholarship can keep a student in college, a mentor can provide confidence, and a training programme can create a pathway towards meaningful employment. This is why investment in youth should not be viewed simply as financial support. It is an investment in the future workforce, the future economy and the future strength of communities.

THE ENERGY OF INDIA'S YOUTH

India's large young population is a powerful force of talent, creativity and ambition, driving progress in every field.



Technology is breaking barriers, enabling youth from every corner of India to access opportunities and global platforms.

The Courage to Question and Create

Progress depends on people being willing to try, fail, learn and try again. Young people should be encouraged to experiment fearlessly, question existing systems and explore new ideas without being limited by conventional thinking. Failure should be seen not as a setback, but as an opportunity to learn, improve and grow. By embracing curiosity, creativity and innovation, young minds can develop solutions that create meaningful and lasting impact.

Giving Youth a Seat at the Table

Young people should be part of the conversations that shape the future, with their perspectives recognised as valuable contributions to decision-making. Listening to youth is not simply about giving them a platform; it is about recognising that their experiences, ideas and aspirations can lead to more informed and inclusive decisions across areas such as education, employment, technology, the environment and community development. Creating space for young voices today can help build stronger, more responsive communities for tomorrow.

Young People as Changemakers

Across India and around the world, young people are increasingly demonstrating that meaningful change does not always require a powerful position or a large organisation. It often begins with an individual noticing a problem and deciding to do something about it. Young volunteers participate in educational initiatives, environmental campaigns, blood donation drives, community programmes and social enterprises. Some teach children after school, while others work to protect local water bodies, support elderly people or create opportunities for disadvantaged communities. Many young entrepreneurs are also attempting to solve social problems through technology and innovative business models. The scale of these initiatives may differ, but their significance should not be underestimated. A student teaching a child to read may influence one life. A group restoring a local lake may inspire an entire neighbourhood. A young entrepreneur creating employment may provide opportunities to dozens of people. Social impact often begins with small actions that gradually become larger movements.

The Role of Businesses and Communities

Youth empowerment requires a collective effort. Businesses can support young people through internships, mentorship, skill development and entrepreneurship opportunities, helping them gain practical experience and confidence. Educational institutions can encourage practical learning and equip students with future-ready skills, while NGOs can create opportunities for volunteering and meaningful community participation. Families and communities also play an important role by building confidence, encouraging continuous learning and helping young people view failures as opportunities to grow. Together, they can create a supportive ecosystem where young people have the guidance and confidence to learn, lead and thrive.

The Future is Already Being Built

The future is already being built in classrooms, workplaces, communities, laboratories and start-ups, as well as through countless small acts of service and everyday contributions. Young people are learning, experimenting, creating and taking action in ways that are shaping the world around them. Every new idea, skill, initiative and act of responsibility contributes to the society we are building. The future is not something that will arrive tomorrow; it is being created today through the choices, efforts and actions of people who are willing to make a difference.

India's Electric Shift: From Petrol to Possibility

India is entering a new chapter in transportation. Across cities and towns, electric scooters, cars, buses and three-wheelers are becoming increasingly common, signalling a shift in how the country thinks about mobility. Electric Vehicles (EVs) are no longer simply a futuristic concept; they are becoming an important part of India's evolving transportation ecosystem.

Unlike conventional vehicles that depend on petrol or diesel engines, EVs use electricity stored in batteries to power an electric motor. This technology offers a quieter driving experience, fewer tailpipe emissions and the opportunity to reduce dependence on fossil fuels. With improvements in battery technology and charging infrastructure, electric mobility is becoming more accessible to a wider range of consumers.

A Cleaner Way to Move

One of the biggest attractions of electric mobility is its potential environmental benefit. Fully electric vehicles produce no tailpipe emissions while operating, which can be particularly valuable in densely populated cities. As India's electricity generation increasingly incorporates renewable sources such as solar and wind, the environmental advantages of EVs can become even stronger.

Electric mobility can also contribute to India's broader efforts to improve energy efficiency and reduce its reliance on imported fossil fuels. By shifting part of transportation's energy demand from petroleum towards electricity, India can create a more diversified and potentially more resilient energy system. Over time, wider EV adoption could also help improve urban air quality and reduce noise pollution. This transition represents an important step towards building cleaner, smarter and more sustainable cities for future generations. It can also encourage innovation across battery technology, charging infrastructure and clean-energy solutions, strengthening India's sustainable mobility ecosystem.

Beyond reducing emissions, electric mobility is also reshaping how cities think about transportation. The growth of EVs is encouraging investments in smarter charging networks, renewable-powered mobility solutions and better public transport integration. As technology continues to improve, electric vehicles can become more accessible, efficient and practical for a wider range of users. This evolution can help India move towards a transportation system that is not only cleaner, but also more connected, innovative and prepared for the demands of a rapidly urbanising future.



India's EV Ecosystem Is Expanding

The EV revolution is not limited to private cars. Electric two-wheelers have become an important part of urban mobility, while electric three-wheelers are transforming last-mile transportation. Electric buses are also emerging as a promising option for public transport, offering cities an opportunity to modernise their fleets.

This growing variety is important for India because transportation needs differ significantly across regions. A compact electric scooter may be ideal for daily urban commuting, while an electric bus or three-wheeler can serve larger public and commercial transportation needs. At the same time, the expansion of charging infrastructure and battery technology is making electric mobility more practical and accessible. Together, these developments are creating a stronger ecosystem that can support India's transition towards cleaner and smarter transportation.

The expansion of the EV ecosystem is also creating new opportunities across manufacturing, technology and employment. From battery production and charging networks to software, vehicle servicing and energy management, electric mobility is encouraging the growth of new industries and skills. As domestic capabilities strengthen and innovation accelerates, India has the potential to build a more self-reliant EV value chain while supporting economic growth. This broader ecosystem can make electric mobility not just a transportation transition, but an important driver of India's industrial and technological future.

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Charging: Building the Infrastructure of Tomorrow

A strong charging network is essential for the continued growth of electric mobility. Home charging can be convenient for many private EV owners, while public charging infrastructure is particularly important for people travelling longer distances and for commercial vehicles. As charging networks expand, faster charging technologies and smarter energy-management systems can make EV ownership increasingly convenient. Integrating charging infrastructure with renewable energy could further strengthen the connection between clean transportation and clean power.

A New Opportunity for India

The EV transition presents India with an opportunity to develop its own strengths in manufacturing, technology and innovation. Building domestic capabilities in batteries, components and charging infrastructure can reduce dependence on imported technologies while creating new economic opportunities. It can also encourage collaboration between automobile companies, technology firms, startups, energy companies and educational institutions. Such partnerships can accelerate innovation and help create solutions designed specifically for Indian roads and consumers.

Innovation Beyond the Vehicle

The electric-vehicle revolution is creating an ecosystem of innovation that goes beyond vehicles. Batteries, charging stations, power electronics, software and energy-management systems are becoming key parts of the automotive industry. Indian startups and established companies are developing new solutions in battery technology, charging infrastructure and connected mobility, creating opportunities for research, entrepreneurship and manufacturing. This growth is also generating new skills and employment while strengthening domestic supply chains. As EV adoption expands, it can drive innovation across multiple industries and support India's transition towards a smarter, more sustainable and technology-driven mobility economy. It can also encourage greater investment in clean-energy technologies and advanced manufacturing. The integration of EVs with renewable energy and smart infrastructure can improve efficiency across the mobility ecosystem. Together, these developments can position India as a growing hub for next-generation transportation solutions.



Looking Ahead

India's electric-mobility journey is entering a defining phase, driven by rapid advances in battery technology, charging infrastructure, vehicle affordability and domestic manufacturing. What began as an emerging alternative to conventional transportation is steadily evolving into a larger transformation of the country's mobility and energy landscape. As the EV ecosystem expands, electric mobility is becoming an important part of India's vision for cleaner energy, smarter technology and sustainable economic growth.

The road ahead will be shaped by continued innovation, wider charging networks, stronger domestic supply chains and greater collaboration between government, industry, technology companies and consumers. From electric cars and two-wheelers to buses and commercial vehicles, the transition has the potential to reshape how people and goods move across the country. It can also create new opportunities in battery manufacturing, renewable energy, software, infrastructure and skilled employment.

As India's roads become increasingly electric, the impact of this transition will extend well beyond transportation. A stronger EV ecosystem can contribute to cleaner cities, improved energy efficiency, reduced dependence on imported fossil fuels and the development of future-ready industries. With sustained investment and innovation, India has an opportunity not only to adopt electric mobility at scale, but also to become a significant force in shaping the next generation of global transportation.

Battery Electric Vehicles (BEVs)



Plug-in Hybrid Electric Vehicles (PHEVs)



Hybrid Electric Vehicles (HEVs)



Fuel-cell Electric Vehicles (FCEVs)



"The electric revolution is more than a transformation in how India moves it is a bold step towards a cleaner, smarter and more sustainable future, with India ready to lead the journey of mobility into a new era."

TAMILNADU: A STATE WRITING ITS NEW CHAPTER

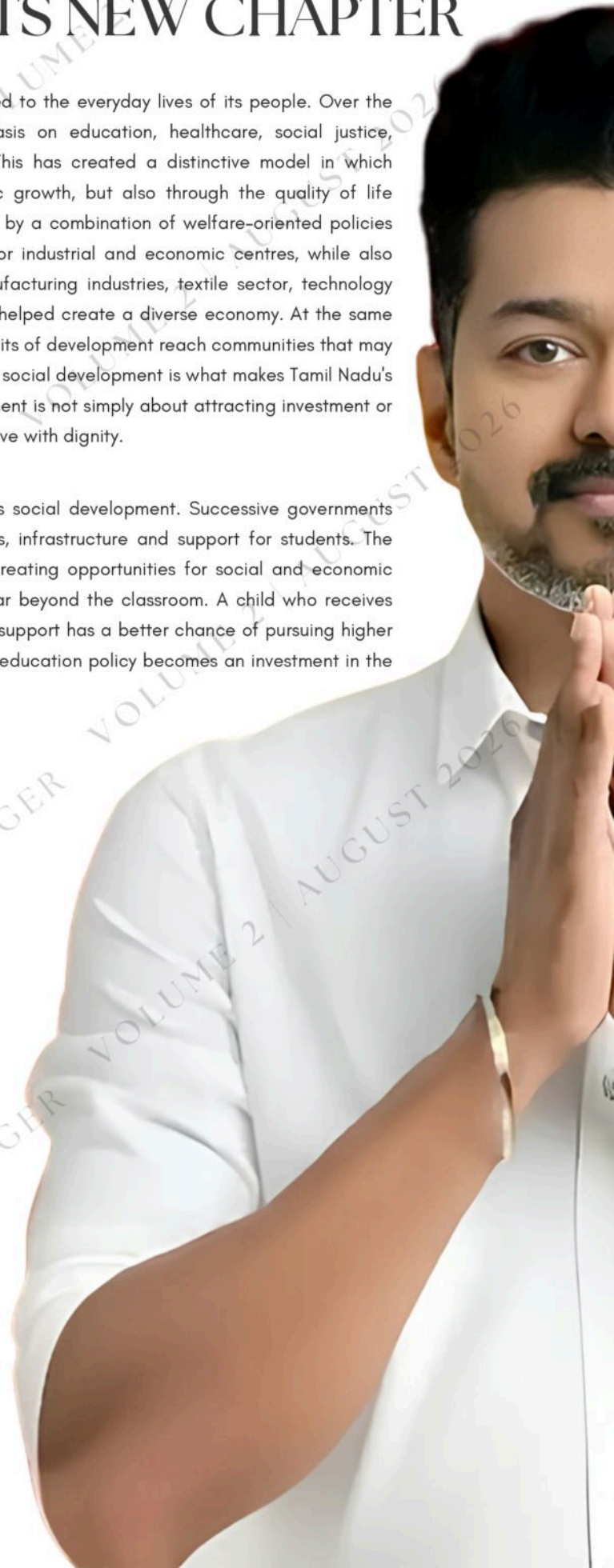
Tamil Nadu has always been a state where politics is closely connected to the everyday lives of its people. Over the decades, successive governments have placed considerable emphasis on education, healthcare, social justice, women's empowerment, food security and economic development. This has created a distinctive model in which governance is not measured only through infrastructure or economic growth, but also through the quality of life experienced by ordinary families. The state's journey has been shaped by a combination of welfare-oriented policies and economic ambition. Tamil Nadu today stands among India's major industrial and economic centres, while also maintaining a strong public welfare system. Its automobile and manufacturing industries, textile sector, technology ecosystem, healthcare institutions and educational infrastructure have helped create a diverse economy. At the same time, government programmes have attempted to ensure that the benefits of development reach communities that may otherwise be left behind. This balance between economic progress and social development is what makes Tamil Nadu's story particularly significant. The state has demonstrated that development is not simply about attracting investment or building infrastructure. It is also about giving people the opportunity to live with dignity.

A Development Model Built Around People

Education has been one of the strongest foundations of Tamil Nadu's social development. Successive governments have invested in school education, scholarships, nutrition programmes, infrastructure and support for students. The objective has gradually expanded from simply improving literacy to creating opportunities for social and economic mobility. Programs that support children at school can have effects far beyond the classroom. A child who receives adequate nutrition, remains in school and receives proper educational support has a better chance of pursuing higher education or finding meaningful employment later in life. In this sense, education policy becomes an investment in the future of an entire family.

Tamil Nadu's emphasis on nutrition is equally important to its broader social development. Initiatives such as the Chief Minister's Breakfast Scheme recognise a basic but often overlooked reality: children cannot learn effectively when they are hungry. By ensuring that students receive a nutritious meal before beginning their school day, the scheme addresses an immediate need while also supporting regular attendance, concentration and classroom participation. What may appear to be a simple intervention can therefore create a much larger long-term impact by improving educational outcomes and giving children a stronger foundation for their future. It also reflects the idea that education is not limited to classrooms, but depends on creating the right conditions for children to learn and grow. By investing in children today, the state strengthens the human capital that will shape Tamil Nadu's future.

Healthcare has been another important pillar of Tamil Nadu's development story. The state has built an extensive public healthcare network consisting of primary health centres, government hospitals and specialised medical institutions, creating access to essential services across both urban and rural areas. This network has played a significant role in making healthcare more affordable and accessible, particularly for families who may not have the financial capacity to depend on expensive private treatment. Together with investments in maternal care, preventive health and specialised services, Tamil Nadu's public healthcare approach reflects a broader commitment to ensuring that development reaches people at the most fundamental level.



The impact of healthcare policies is often most visible during moments of crisis. For an ordinary family, access to an affordable hospital, timely treatment or maternal healthcare can make the difference between financial security and severe hardship. This is why the strength of a public healthcare system cannot be judged only by the number of hospitals it operates. Its real value lies in whether people can access care when they need it.

Women, Families and Changing Opportunities

Another significant part of Tamil Nadu's social transformation has been the growing focus on women. Women's access to education, employment, public transport and financial assistance has expanded over the years. These changes have affected not only women themselves but also the families and communities around them. Economic independence can change the decisions a woman is able to make. Access to education can change the opportunities available to a girl. Affordable transportation can determine whether a student can attend college or whether a woman can travel to work. These are everyday issues, but together they contribute to a much larger transformation in society. Tamil Nadu's development story is therefore also a story about changing aspirations. Families increasingly expect daughters to study, work and build independent lives. Young women are participating more actively in higher education, entrepreneurship and the workforce. Government programmes alone cannot create this transformation, but they can make it easier for people to take advantage of opportunities that already exist.

From Welfare to Economic Opportunity

Tamil Nadu's achievements cannot be discussed only through the lens of welfare. The state has also developed one of India's strongest industrial and manufacturing ecosystems. The automobile sector, electronics, textiles, information technology, renewable energy, engineering and healthcare have contributed significantly to the state's economy. Chennai and its surrounding industrial areas have attracted major companies, while cities such as Coimbatore, Hosur, Tiruppur, Salem, Madurai and Trichy have developed important economic identities of their own. Industrial growth has an impact that extends beyond the companies making investments. When a new manufacturing unit is established, it creates direct employment, but it can also generate opportunities for transport operators, suppliers, small businesses, restaurants, housing providers and service companies. Over time, an industrial project can therefore create an entire economic ecosystem.

This connection between investment and people's lives is particularly important for Tamil Nadu's young population. Employment is one of the clearest ways in which economic growth becomes meaningful to an individual. A large investment figure may look impressive on paper. Its real significance is found in the young graduate who receives a job, the family that gains a stable income and the small business that grows because a larger industrial ecosystem has developed nearby.

Vijay: From Cinema to Politics

For decades, Vijay built a powerful public presence beyond his successful cinema career through organized fan networks engaged in blood donation drives, welfare programs, and crisis relief. His films frequently tackled social issues like corruption, unemployment, and inequality, establishing him as a voice for social responsibility among youth. Leveraging this long-cultivated grassroots foundation, Vijay formally entered Tamil Nadu's political arena in February 2024 with the launch of Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam, continuing the state's storied tradition of cinema figures transitioning into public life.

Chandrasekaran Joseph Vijay
Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu

A New Political Chapter for Tamil Nadu

Vijay's arrival at the helm of Tamil Nadu's government in 2026 marks a new chapter in the state's political and economic journey. Inheriting a strong welfare foundation, a powerful industrial ecosystem and high public expectations, the new administration has placed emphasis on investment, employment and economic expansion, with major investment agreements announced across electronics, automobiles, renewable energy, space technology, healthcare and emerging industries. The real measure of this transformation will be how effectively these commitments translate into jobs, innovation and opportunities across the state. Tamil Nadu's strength extends beyond Chennai, with Coimbatore, Tiruppur, Hosur, Madurai, Salem and Trichy contributing to its economic potential. By extending these strategic opportunities to regional hubs, the state can foster balanced economic growth. This inclusive vision aims to turn local investments into lasting opportunities for youth across every district.

Measuring Impact Beyond Statistics

Government achievements are often communicated through numbers - the amount invested, the number of beneficiaries, kilometres of roads constructed, jobs promised or funds allocated. But numbers tell only part of the story. The real impact of governance can be seen in everyday experiences. It is the student who remains in school because financial pressure on the family has been reduced. It is the woman who gains greater independence because she can travel to work or access financial support. It is the patient who receives treatment without having to sell family assets. It is the young graduate who finds employment without leaving the district. It is the farmer who receives support during a difficult season. It is the small entrepreneur whose business expands because a new industrial ecosystem has emerged. These individual changes may not always make headlines, but together they define the success of public policy.



Tamil Nadu's greatest strength has been its ability to combine social development with economic ambition. Welfare provides a safety net, while industry and employment create opportunities. Education prepares people for those opportunities, and healthcare helps protect families from the economic shock of illness. The challenge for every government is to maintain this balance.

The Road Ahead for Vijay

For Vijay, the transition from actor to Chief Minister represents the beginning of a much more demanding phase. Cinema provided him with an enormous public platform. Politics provided him with an opportunity to turn public influence into political participation. Governance now requires something different - consistent administration, accountability, long-term planning and measurable results. His government will eventually be judged not by the excitement surrounding its arrival, but by the changes people experience in their daily lives.

The emphasis on investment and employment is one part of that journey. Maintaining Tamil Nadu's established strengths in education, healthcare and social welfare will be another. The real challenge will be bringing these priorities together.

Economic growth without inclusion can widen inequality. Welfare without economic opportunity can become difficult to sustain. Industrialisation without environmental responsibility can create long-term problems. Good governance lies in finding a practical balance between all three. Tamil Nadu also faces emerging challenges that will require long-term thinking - climate change, water security, urban congestion, technological disruption, employment for young people and the changing needs of an increasingly educated population. The government that successfully addresses these issues will not simply improve today's Tamil Nadu; it will shape the Tamil Nadu of the next generation.

A State That Continues to Evolve

Tamil Nadu enters this new political chapter with considerable strengths. It has a skilled and increasingly diverse workforce, established industrial corridors, strong educational institutions, a large entrepreneurial community and decades of experience in building social welfare systems. These foundations give the state an advantage that few regions can easily replicate. Its economy is supported by manufacturing, automobiles, textiles, information technology, electronics, healthcare, education and a growing services sector, creating a broad base for future development.

Vijay's arrival has introduced a new political voice into this established system. His emergence reflects a wider public appetite for new ideas, new leadership and a different style of political engagement. At the same time, the opportunity before his government is not to start Tamil Nadu's development journey from the beginning, but to build on what has already been created. Existing programmes can be strengthened, gaps can be addressed and new approaches can be introduced where changing circumstances demand them.

The real challenge will be to balance continuity with change. Tamil Nadu's development has been built over decades through a combination of public investment, welfare programmes, industrial growth, social reform and educational expansion. Preserving the strengths of this model while making it more efficient, transparent and responsive will require careful policymaking rather than sudden transformation.

“I AM NOT AN ANGEL BUT A COMMON MAN. I WILL NOT PROMISE WHAT WE CANNOT DELIVER, BUT I NOW HAVE CONFIDENCE THAT WE CAN DO ANYTHING WITH YOU. I REQUEST ALL OF YOU TO GIVE ME SOME TIME. I WILL GRADUALLY FULFIL EVERYTHING I HAVE PROMISED AND WILL SINCERELY STRIVE TO IMPLEMENT THEM.

CHANDRASEKHARAN JOSEPH VIJAY
CHIEF MINISTER OF TAMIL NADU



Building the Tamil Nadu of Tomorrow

The next phase of development will increasingly depend on how effectively Tamil Nadu prepares for a changing economy and changing society. Technology, artificial intelligence, automation, climate change, urbanisation and the transition towards cleaner industries are reshaping the opportunities available to the state's younger generation.

For Tamil Nadu's youth, economic growth must translate into meaningful employment, entrepreneurship and opportunities for upward mobility. The state has the potential to become an even stronger centre for advanced manufacturing, technology, research and innovation. But achieving that potential will require closer connections between education and industry, stronger skill development and greater support for young entrepreneurs and emerging businesses.

Equally important is the need to ensure that development remains inclusive. Growth concentrated in major cities cannot alone define the progress of the state. Smaller towns, rural communities and economically weaker regions must also participate in the benefits of investment and infrastructure. Better transport, digital connectivity, healthcare, education and employment opportunities can help reduce the gap between rapidly developing urban centres and other parts of Tamil Nadu.

Women's economic participation will be another important measure of progress. Greater access to education, employment, entrepreneurship, financial independence and safe public spaces can strengthen not only individual families but the wider economy. Similarly, improving public healthcare and strengthening government schools can have a direct impact on the quality of life of millions of citizens.

Ultimately, the success of this chapter will not be determined by political speeches or campaign promises. It will be determined by whether children receive better education, whether families receive better healthcare, whether women gain greater independence, whether young people find meaningful employment and whether economic growth reaches communities across the state.

Tamil Nadu's story has always been a story of change. From social reform movements to welfare politics, from industrialisation to technological growth, the state has repeatedly adapted to new realities. Each generation has inherited an existing foundation and attempted to reshape it according to the challenges of its time.

Now, with new political leadership at the centre of its administration, another chapter has begun.

The expectations are high. The challenges are equally significant. But the measure of progress remains simple: does governance make everyday life better?

For Tamil Nadu, the answer to that question will ultimately define the legacy of this new era.



JEEVIDHAM TRUST

The Power to Transform Communities

Jeevidham Trust's Journey of Empowerment, Inclusion and Community Impact

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Established on 19 June 2018 and based in Adambakkam, Chennai, Jeevidham Trust works with underserved and marginalized communities across Chennai, Chengalpattu and Thiruvallur districts. Its work focuses on education, women's empowerment, health and hygiene, nutrition, livelihoods and community development. Rather than addressing these concerns separately, the Trust follows a community-centred approach in which education, health, livelihoods and dignity work together to create sustainable change.

EDUCATION THAT OPENS DOORS

Education remains one of the Trust's strongest areas of intervention. Through the Path to Progress - After School Programme, children from economically disadvantaged families receive structured academic support across rural centres. The programme focuses on foundational learning and core subjects while using activity-based methods to make learning more engaging. Value-based education, teamwork, discipline and confidence-building are also incorporated into the programme.

Jeevidham Trust believes that learning should extend beyond textbooks. Children receive stationery, learning materials and essential school supplies, while focused support is provided to slow learners. Chess training, library visits, science-centre visits and educational exposure programmes give children opportunities to experience practical learning and develop curiosity and confidence. The Trust's educational exposure visits have included places such as Anna Centenary Library, Birla Planetarium, Periyar Science and Technology Centre, Guindy Children's Park and an organic farm, allowing rural children to experience environments that may otherwise remain outside their everyday lives.

The objective is not simply to improve academic performance, but to create an environment in which children can learn, grow and prepare for their future with confidence.



PROJECT VELICHAM: LEARNING BEYOND THE CLASSROOM

Another major initiative, Project Velicham, extends this educational vision into Government ADW schools and Social Justice Hostels. The programme combines academic assistance with communication and life-skills training, health and hygiene awareness, career guidance and vocational development. Infrastructure support, including safe drinking water and sanitation facilities, is also part of the initiative. The objective is not simply to improve academic performance, but to create an environment in which children can learn, grow and prepare for their future with confidence.

EMPOWERING WOMEN THROUGH LIVELIHOODS

Alongside education, women's empowerment forms an important part of Jeevidham Trust's work. Through Self-Help Groups, vocational training and livelihood initiatives, women are supported in developing practical skills and exploring sustainable income opportunities. Training in household and commercial product preparation, entrepreneurship and other livelihood activities helps women strengthen their financial independence and confidence.

One example is the Areca Leaf Plate Making Initiative in Pallipuram Village. The project provided an automatic areca-leaf plate-making machine along with training and operational support to women from a Self-Help Group. Seventeen women were enabled to move towards self-employment, benefiting more than 60 family members. The initiative created an opportunity for more stable income while encouraging the production of biodegradable alternatives to plastic products. The report states that beneficiaries are generating approximately ₹8,000-₹10,000 in monthly income through this activity.

CARING FOR COMMUNITY WELL-BEING

Jeevidham Trust's approach to community well-being also includes responding to immediate needs. Through the Love Meals Project, nutritious meals are provided to vulnerable individuals and families, including daily-wage workers, elderly people and marginalized communities. The programme addresses food insecurity while emphasizing dignity and care. The Trust also conducts medical camps, health and hygiene awareness sessions, menstrual health programmes, mental-health awareness activities and initiatives to improve access to safe drinking water. Together, these interventions reflect an approach that combines immediate humanitarian support with longer-term community well-being.

REACHING THOUSANDS, CREATING CHANGE

During 2025-2026, the Trust's wider education, empowerment and community-development initiatives reached 5,000+ beneficiaries, with children supported through after-school learning programmes and women benefiting from vocational and livelihood initiatives. This scale demonstrates how multiple small interventions can create broader social impact across education, nutrition, health, employment and empowerment.



CSR THAT CREATES LASTING VALUE

The Trust's CSR initiatives demonstrate how targeted interventions can create lasting community value. At the Government Adi Dravidar Welfare Primary School in Pallipuram, Thiruvallur District, students had been facing challenges because existing sanitation facilities were broken and unusable.

With CSR support from Rox Hi-Tech, the project created separate toilet blocks for boys, girls and staff, along with an accessible toilet facility. Water supply systems, drainage, handwashing facilities and hygiene-awareness murals were also introduced. The intervention helped create a safer and more supportive learning environment, with the report noting improvements in hygiene, dignity and privacy and increased attendance, particularly among girls. This initiative illustrates how CSR can move beyond financial contribution to address a specific community need and create an environment where children can learn safely and with dignity.

INCLUSION, EMPOWERMENT & SUSTAINABLE IMPACT

Jeevidham Trust's commitment to inclusive development is reflected in initiatives supporting 400 persons with disabilities through food distribution and awareness programmes, while its International Women's Day initiative reached 1,000+ women students and faculty and distributed 1,000 tree saplings, combining empowerment with environmental responsibility. Working with schools, institutions, volunteers, corporates and social organisations, the Trust connects education, health, livelihoods, inclusion and sustainability to create meaningful opportunities and stronger, more self-reliant communities. **Because lasting impact begins when compassion is transformed into opportunity, and opportunity is given the space to create a better future.**

MEET THE FOUNDER

DR. I. MARY METILDA



E20[🌱]

FROM FARM TO FUEL

How Ethanol Is Reshaping India's Energy Future

When we stop at a petrol station and fill our vehicle, we usually think about the price on the screen and how far the fuel will take us. We rarely think about where that fuel came from or how many industries are connected to it. E20 petrol changes that story. E20 means petrol blended with up to 20% ethanol, a renewable fuel that can be produced from agricultural resources. India's move towards E20 is part of a larger effort to reduce its dependence on imported fossil fuels, make greater use of domestic energy resources and move towards a more sustainable energy future. But E20 is not simply about putting a different fuel into vehicles. It connects the farmer, the factory, the automobile industry and the consumer in one chain. A crop can become ethanol, ethanol can become part of petrol, and that fuel can eventually power a vehicle on an Indian road. That is what makes the E20 journey much bigger than a fuel-blending programme.

WHY INDIA IS MAKING THE SHIFT

India needs enormous amounts of energy to keep its economy and transportation system moving. For years, the country has depended heavily on imported crude oil, which means changes in global oil prices and international events can directly affect the Indian economy. Ethanol gives India an opportunity to produce part of its fuel requirement domestically. By increasing ethanol blending, India can reduce some of its dependence on imported petroleum and make greater use of resources available within the country.

There is also an economic side to this change. Instead of sending all the money associated with fuel demand outside the country through crude-oil imports, a larger domestic ethanol ecosystem can create opportunities for farmers, distilleries, transporters, manufacturers and rural businesses. For India, energy security is not only about having enough fuel. It is also about having more control over where that energy comes from.

WHEN THE FARM BECOMES PART OF THE FUEL SYSTEM

One of the most human parts of the E20 story is its connection with agriculture. Ethanol can be produced from feedstocks such as sugarcane and maize. This creates another source of demand for suitable agricultural produce and brings farmers into the country's changing energy landscape. For a farmer, the idea is not about fuel policy or energy statistics. It can simply mean having another market for agricultural produce. For rural areas, a growing ethanol industry can also mean opportunities in processing, transportation, storage and other supporting activities. But this opportunity needs to be handled carefully. Agriculture is not only about producing fuel it is also about feeding people. Land and water are limited, and crops used for ethanol must be managed responsibly. If the expansion of ethanol places excessive pressure on water resources or creates unhealthy competition between food and fuel, some of its benefits could be weakened. The challenge is not just to produce more ethanol, but to produce it responsibly.

DID YOU KNOW?

E20 connects India's farms, industries, fuel stations and vehicles in one energy ecosystem turning agricultural resources into a component of the fuel that powers everyday mobility.

THE ENERGY SECURITY ADVANTAGE

One of the strongest arguments for E20 is its potential to strengthen India's energy security. The country cannot decide what happens to global crude-oil prices, but it can decide how much it wants to depend on imported fossil fuels. Increasing the use of domestically produced ethanol can help diversify the country's fuel sources. It can also encourage investment in domestic production facilities, technology and infrastructure. This does not mean ethanol will make India completely independent of crude oil. Instead, it gives the country another piece of the energy puzzle. And when a country has more options, it becomes better prepared for an uncertain world.

THE ENVIRONMENTAL SIDE

Ethanol is a renewable fuel, which gives it an important role in India's efforts to reduce the environmental impact of transportation. When produced sustainably, ethanol can have a lower lifecycle greenhouse-gas intensity than conventional fossil fuels. This makes E20 part of a larger conversation about cleaner energy. But there is no single fuel that can solve the climate challenge by itself. The environmental benefit of ethanol depends heavily on how it is produced. Water use, agricultural practices, energy consumption during processing and transportation all matter. So the real environmental question is not simply "Is ethanol renewable?" It is "How sustainably are we producing it?"

WHAT DOES IT MEAN FOR VEHICLE OWNERS?

For drivers, E20 becomes real the moment they start thinking about their vehicle. The transition towards higher ethanol blends requires vehicles to be compatible with those fuels. Automobile manufacturers have therefore been adapting engines, fuel systems and other components to work with higher ethanol blends. There is also the question of mileage. Ethanol contains less energy per litre than petrol, so vehicles using higher ethanol blends can experience some reduction in fuel economy, depending on the vehicle and driving conditions. For an everyday driver, this distinction matters. A fuel that costs a certain amount per litre does not necessarily have the same cost per kilometre. At the same time, newer vehicles designed to work with higher ethanol blends can make the transition easier.

THE WATER QUESTION

One of the concerns surrounding ethanol production is water consumption, particularly when the feedstock comes from water-intensive crops in regions where water is already under pressure. This is where India's future approach to ethanol becomes important. Better irrigation, improved agricultural practices, efficient processing and the use of alternative feedstocks can help reduce pressure on natural resources. The country therefore needs to think beyond the question of how much ethanol can be produced and focus equally on how efficiently and sustainably it can be produced.

TURNING AGRICULTURAL WASTE INTO ENERGY

Perhaps one of the most exciting possibilities lies in second-generation ethanol. Instead of relying mainly on crops, advanced technologies can convert agricultural residues and biomass into fuel. This opens an interesting possibility for India. Crop residues that might otherwise be burned or discarded could become a useful source of energy. Imagine looking at agricultural waste differently not as something to get rid of, but as something that can be put to productive use. That could help India move towards a more circular approach where waste becomes a resource.

THE ENERGY SECURITY ADVANTAGE

One of the strongest arguments for E20 is its potential to strengthen India's energy security. The country cannot decide what happens to global crude-oil prices, but it can decide how much it wants to depend on imported fossil fuels. Increasing the use of domestically produced ethanol can help diversify the country's fuel sources. It can also encourage investment in domestic production facilities, technology and infrastructure. This does not mean ethanol will make India completely independent of crude oil. Instead, it gives the country another piece of the energy puzzle. And when a country has more options, it becomes better prepared for an uncertain world.

DRIVING INDIA TOWARDS ENERGY SELF-RELIANCE

E20 is more than a change at the petrol pump—it represents a wider economic, agricultural and energy transformation for India. Its ecosystem brings together farmers, industries, transport networks, fuel companies and automobile manufacturers, creating opportunities for jobs, rural industries, investment and greater energy self-reliance. But the transition also comes with challenges, including fuel-economy impacts, vehicle compatibility and pressure on water and agricultural resources. The real opportunity lies in balancing economic growth, energy security, environmental responsibility and food security. From a crop in a farmer's field to ethanol in a processing plant and fuel on India's roads, E20 connects everyday mobility with a much larger national story. If managed responsibly, it can create new economic opportunities, strengthen domestic energy systems and contribute to a more diversified and sustainable future for India.



"From the farmer's field to the nation's roads, E20 is more than fuel it is a journey towards India's energy independence and sustainable growth."

Social Stock Exchange

Capital for a Stronger,
More Inclusive Tomorrow



By The Impact Ledger | August 2026

A DIFFERENT KIND OF EXCHANGE

When people hear the words “Stock Exchange,” they usually think of shares, prices, companies and financial returns. But the Social Stock Exchange (SSE) is built around a different idea. It is a specialised segment within the securities-market ecosystem that provides eligible social organisations with a structured platform to raise funds for activities that create social impact. Operating under the regulatory framework of SEBI, the SSE brings social organisations and potential funders closer together, while placing importance on transparency, disclosures and accountability.

WHY IT WAS CREATED

India has no shortage of organisations working to improve people's lives. Across the country, NGOs and social enterprises are working in education, healthcare, livelihoods, nutrition, sanitation, gender equality, environmental sustainability and many other areas. Yet one challenge appears again and again: access to reliable funding. An organisation may understand a community's problems perfectly and have a strong solution, but without financial resources, even the best idea can remain an idea. The SSE was created to provide a more organised pathway through which eligible social organisations can access funding and connect with institutions and individuals who want to support meaningful social causes.

BRINGING TWO WORLDS TOGETHER

The SSE bridges social purpose and capital by connecting organisations addressing real-world challenges with funders seeking credible social-impact opportunities. It enables eligible organisations to present their work, share key information and raise funds through permitted mechanisms, creating greater structure and transparency.

HOW AN ORGANISATION BECOMES PART OF IT

Participation in the SSE begins with eligibility and registration. An NPO cannot simply enter the platform and start collecting funds. It has to satisfy the applicable regulatory requirements and complete the prescribed registration process. Relevant information about the organisation, its activities, governance and other required areas must be disclosed. Registration itself does not guarantee funding; instead, it places the organisation within a framework where fundraising and reporting are subject to defined requirements.

THE FUNDRAISING PROCESS

Once eligible, an organisation can use the fundraising mechanisms permitted under the SSE framework. One of the most distinctive mechanisms available to NPOs is the Zero Coupon Zero Principal (ZCZP) instrument. Through this mechanism, eligible NPOs can raise funds for specific social projects without paying interest or returning the principal to the subscriber. The idea is very different from a conventional investment. The contributor is not looking for a financial return; the purpose is to support a social outcome.



WHEN THE RETURN IS SOCIAL

The concept behind ZCZP becomes easier to understand when we put a human face to it. Imagine an organisation wants to train young people from underserved communities so that they can find employment. The programme needs funding for training, materials and implementation. Through an eligible ZCZP issue, funds can be raised for that purpose. The contributor does not receive interest or repayment of the principal, but if those funds help young people gain skills and build better livelihoods, the impact becomes the real return. The instrument may be financial in structure, but the outcome it seeks is human.

WHY TRANSPARENCY MATTERS

Whenever money is involved, trust becomes important. A company or institution supporting an organisation wants to understand who is receiving the money, what the project is about and how the funds are intended to be used. The SSE framework addresses this through requirements relating to disclosures, reporting and accountability. Participating organisations are expected to provide relevant information about their work and activities. This encourages a shift from simply saying, "We are doing good work," to clearly explaining what problem is being addressed, what solution is being proposed and what impact is expected.

FROM FUNDING TO IMPACT

The SSE is not designed to make fundraising the final goal. Raising money is only the beginning of the journey. The more important question is what happens after the funds reach the project. If money is raised for education, do children actually receive better learning opportunities? If the purpose is healthcare, did the programme reach the people who needed it? If the objective is livelihood creation, did families gain sustainable opportunities? This is why social-impact reporting and social-audit mechanisms form an important part of the wider SSE framework. The focus moves beyond money raised towards change created.

WHO DOES IT HELP?

The SSE can serve different parts of the social-impact ecosystem. For Not-for-Profit Organisations, it provides an additional structured route to raise funds for eligible social projects. For social enterprises, it creates a regulated environment through which they can access capital while demonstrating their social purpose. For funders, it offers greater visibility into participating organisations and the initiatives they are supporting. But ultimately, the most important stakeholder is the community the children, families, women, young people and communities whose lives these projects are intended to improve.

IT IS A FRAMEWORK, NOT A GUARANTEE

The SSE does not guarantee funding or success. Organisations must demonstrate credibility, meet requirements and deliver responsibly. The platform provides the structure and opportunity; real impact depends on the organisations, funders and communities involved.



THE PEOPLE BEHIND THE NUMBERS

Social projects are often presented through numbers how many beneficiaries will be reached, how much money is required or how many activities will be completed. But behind every number is a human story. A target of 500 students could mean 500 children receiving an opportunity to learn. A healthcare programme reaching 1,000 people could mean 1,000 individuals getting access to support they desperately need. A livelihood programme for 200 women could mean 200 families moving towards greater financial independence. The numbers describe the project, but the people give it meaning.

CAPITAL THAT CAN CREATE POSSIBILITY

The Social Stock Exchange (SSE) represents a new way of thinking about capital looking beyond financial returns to ask what social value resources can create. By connecting eligible social organisations with potential funders, the SSE provides a structured pathway to present their work, mobilise resources, strengthen transparency and remain accountable for outcomes. Its significance lies not simply in the amount of capital raised, but in how effectively that capital translates into measurable change better education, stronger livelihoods, improved healthcare and greater opportunities for communities. The SSE does not guarantee funding or impact; rather, it creates the framework and opportunity for organisations to turn good intentions into meaningful action. Ultimately, its real measure of success will not be found in numbers alone, but in the lives improved, communities strengthened and possibilities created. It is, at its core, an effort to give capital a purpose and give social purpose a better chance of finding the capital it needs.



"The greatest return is not always the money that comes back; sometimes, it is the future that moves forward."

Continuation in next edition...

HERITAGE IN ACTION

THE AMERICAN TELUGU ASSOCIATION

Preserving Our Heritage • Empowering Our Community • Building a Better Tomorrow

Some organizations are built around events. Others are built around a purpose that continues long after an event ends. The American Telugu Association (ATA) belongs to the latter. For more than three decades, ATA has worked to preserve Telugu heritage while creating a strong support system for communities across North America and India. Formally incorporated in Illinois in September 1990, ATA emerged at a time when the Telugu-speaking population in the United States was growing rapidly. Professionals, students and families were establishing new lives across the country, but there was a growing need for a national platform that could connect communities, preserve cultural identity and provide practical support. ATA was created to address these needs through a community-funded and democratically governed organization. At the heart of ATA's work are three interconnected ideas: preserving heritage, empowering people and building a better tomorrow. Its programs therefore extend far beyond cultural celebrations. Scholarships, educational guidance, professional development, health initiatives, youth leadership, entrepreneurship, humanitarian assistance and crisis response have all become part of its wider mission.

From Cultural Roots to Community Strength

ATA's early founders recognized two important gaps within the growing diaspora. The first was cultural. As children grew up thousands of miles away from their ancestral homeland, there was a genuine concern that language, literature, traditions and connections between generations could gradually weaken. The second was practical. Families living far from their traditional support systems could find themselves alone during difficult situations. A student facing an immigration crisis, a family dealing with an unexpected death, or someone requiring emergency assistance might not know where to turn.

ATA's response was to bring these two needs together. Its philosophy was simple but powerful: cultural belonging and community service should strengthen one another. The organization's first Telugu Conference and Youth Convention was held in Chicago in 1991 and attracted approximately 1,500 participants. The following year's convention in New York drew around 4,000 people, demonstrating the demand for a national platform. Over the years, ATA expanded its work through specialized service wings, educational initiatives, youth programs, professional forums and humanitarian activities.

Today, the organization combines cultural programming with year-round community service. Its 2026 convention in Baltimore brought together community members, professionals, entrepreneurs, physicians, artists, young people and public officials through cultural, educational, health, business programs.



Service When It Matters Most

One of ATA's most distinctive areas of work is ATA SEVA, which provides guidance and coordination during emergencies. Its volunteers support families dealing with situations such as sudden deaths, hospitalizations, missing persons, domestic violence concerns, safety issues, emergency documentation and repatriation. This work often happens quietly. Volunteers may coordinate with hospitals, attorneys, consular officials, funeral homes, local organizations and families, helping people navigate complicated situations when they are under immense emotional pressure.

The organization has also responded to student crises. During the 2019 University of Farmington situation, ATA worked with attorneys, community organizations and consular contacts to help affected international students and their families access information and appropriate guidance. The organization emphasizes that its role was to connect vulnerable people with professional and legal resources rather than promise outcomes. Another example involved a road accident in Alabama in which a husband lost his life while his wife remained hospitalized. ATA volunteers helped coordinate communication, documentation, fundraising, consular requirements and arrangements for transporting the deceased to India. Such cases demonstrate that community service is sometimes measured not in headlines or awards, but in being present when families need support the most.

"WHEN HERITAGE BECOMES A FOUNDATION FOR SERVICE,
IDENTITY BECOMES A FORCE FOR LASTING IMPACT."

MEET JAYANTH CHALLA
THE PRESIDENT,
AMERICAN TELUGU ASSOCIATION



Investing in the Next Generation

ATA's impact also extends to education and youth development. Scholarships, academic guidance, SAT coaching, mentoring and support for students in both North America and India are designed to create opportunities that extend beyond immediate assistance. Through the ATA Foundation, initiatives such as My School - My Responsibility, Adopt a Village and Adopt a Student focus on school improvement, safe drinking water, sanitation, education, health and quality of life in Telugu-speaking regions of India, helping build stronger and more empowered communities.

The organization also recognizes that today's students need more than traditional academic support. Technology and professional training have become important parts of its work, with programs covering artificial intelligence, machine learning, cloud computing, cybersecurity, data engineering, software development and business intelligence. Entrepreneurship initiatives, startup competitions, innovation showcases and mentoring further connect young professionals with experienced leaders. This approach reflects a broader understanding of empowerment: providing people not only with assistance today, but with knowledge, skills and networks that can create opportunities tomorrow.



Turning Community Into Lasting Impact

ATA's work demonstrates that impact is not always a single measurable event. Sometimes it is a scholarship that changes a student's direction. Sometimes it is a school receiving better facilities. Sometimes it is a family finding support during a crisis. And sometimes it is a young person discovering their language and heritage and eventually becoming a volunteer themselves. A review of ATA's documented activity across 19 consecutive quarters recorded 273 programs, events and service initiatives, with activity reported in every quarter reviewed. For an organization whose work spans two continents and numerous areas of community life, that continuity is significant.

ATA measures its programs through participation, beneficiary reach, scholarships, funds deployed, services delivered, communities supported, volunteer involvement and geographic coverage. At the same time, the organization acknowledges the need for stronger and more consistent data collection and is working toward a more unified impact framework. Its sustainability model focuses on local ownership, long-term education funding, skills development, durable infrastructure and institutional continuity. Rather than viewing beneficiaries only as recipients, ATA aims to create a cycle in which today's beneficiaries can become tomorrow's volunteers, mentors and supporters.

A Future Built on Heritage and Responsibility

Looking ahead, ATA's priorities include strengthening emergency response, expanding educational access, developing youth and women's leadership, modernizing its digital systems, continuing Foundation projects in India and building stronger partnerships with universities, healthcare institutions, nonprofits, businesses and public agencies. Its philosophy toward CSR is equally significant. ATA views responsible business not simply as financial giving, but as a partnership that combines corporate expertise with genuine community needs. Technology companies can contribute technology and talent; healthcare organizations can contribute medical expertise; businesses can support education, infrastructure and entrepreneurship. The strongest partnerships, according to ATA, are sustained, locally informed and honestly measured. The story of ATA ultimately goes beyond preserving a language or organizing cultural celebrations. It is about transforming heritage into responsibility helping students, supporting families, strengthening communities, developing leaders and creating opportunities for people to serve one another.

Heritage provides the roots. Service gives those roots meaning. And when a community chooses to carry both forward, identity becomes an impact.



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Rural India, New Ideas: Innovation at the Grassroots

Innovation is reshaping rural India in ways that are often quiet but deeply meaningful. Across villages, communities are finding new ways to improve agriculture, create livelihoods, conserve resources and connect with wider markets. These changes show that innovation does not always begin in large cities or technology hubs it can begin with a farmer, an entrepreneur, a student or a community identifying a problem and finding a practical solution. For rural communities, innovation is closely connected to everyday life. A better irrigation method, a solar-powered machine, a digital marketplace or a new approach to processing agricultural produce can make a significant difference. What makes grassroots innovation powerful is its focus on real needs, affordability and practical impact.

Turning Local Challenges into Opportunities

Rural communities often face challenges related to water, transportation, market access, healthcare, education and employment. Instead of simply accepting these limitations, many innovators are developing solutions around the resources already available to them. Agricultural waste, for example, can become a source of value through food processing, composting, bioenergy and other applications. Local skills can be transformed into businesses, while traditional products can reach customers far beyond the village through digital platforms. This approach creates an important shift from viewing rural challenges only as problems to recognising them as opportunities for innovation and entrepreneurship.

Technology as a Rural Enabler

The expansion of digital connectivity brings urban-level opportunities straight to rural communities through smartphones and internet access. These tools connect farmers with crucial weather and market updates, link students with learning resources, and empower local entrepreneurs to accept digital payments while reaching broader markets for their products. Ultimately, widespread connectivity bridges the geographical divide, enabling rural businesses and individuals to make smarter decisions and thrive locally. Technology, however, becomes truly impactful when it is simple, affordable and designed around local requirements. The most successful rural innovations are often those that fit naturally into the way communities already live and work.

Reinventing Agriculture

Agriculture remains one of the biggest areas where rural innovation can create measurable change. Farmers are increasingly exploring precision agriculture, smart irrigation, solar-powered equipment, improved storage and modern farming techniques. These solutions can help make better use of water, energy and land while improving efficiency. Innovations in food processing and storage can also help reduce wastage and allow farmers to earn more value from their produce instead of selling raw products alone. The combination of traditional agricultural knowledge and modern technology can create solutions that are both effective and locally relevant.



The Rise of Rural Entrepreneurship

A new generation of rural entrepreneurs is demonstrating that successful businesses can be built outside major cities. Local food products, handicrafts, textiles, tourism, agricultural services and digital businesses are creating new possibilities for employment and income. Young entrepreneurs are increasingly using social media and e-commerce to tell the stories behind rural products and connect directly with consumers. This can help local enterprises move from small community markets to regional, national and even international audiences. The growth of rural entrepreneurship can also create a ripple effect. One successful business can generate employment, support local suppliers and inspire others to start their own ventures.



Building a Future from the Ground Up

The future of rural innovation lies in collaboration. Government programmes, NGOs, businesses, educational institutions, startups and local communities can work together to identify promising ideas and provide the resources needed to scale them. Funding, mentorship, digital infrastructure, skill development and access to markets can help transform a small village-level idea into a solution with wider impact. Rural innovation reminds us that progress does not always arrive from the top down. Sometimes, it grows from the ground up through local knowledge, determination and creativity.

Expanding the Horizon of Rural Innovation

The true benchmark of rural innovation extends far beyond a simple tally of new technologies deployed or enterprises launched. Sustainable progress is measured by the deep, structural shifts within local ecosystems: resilient livelihoods, self-sustaining community networks, expanding economic mobility, and a higher overall quality of life.

Women Driving Grassroots Change

Women are an important force behind rural innovation. Self-help groups, cooperatives and women-led enterprises are creating opportunities in areas such as food processing, handicrafts, agriculture and small-scale manufacturing. Access to finance, digital tools and markets can help women convert their skills into sustainable businesses. Beyond individual income, these enterprises can contribute to stronger families and more economically active communities. Empowering rural women with skills, technology and market access can therefore multiply the impact of grassroots innovation.

India's villages are no longer passive recipients on the sidelines of national growth. Instead, they are rapidly emerging as vibrant innovation hubs where grassroots challenges spark ground-breaking ideas that are locally tested, iteratively refined, and scaled into transformative, real-world solutions that drive the entire nation forward.



ANVITI FOUNDATION: WHERE COMMUNITY ACTION CREATES LASTING CHANGE

Turning Concern Into Collective Action

The journey of Anviti Foundation began with a simple but powerful inspiration to give back to society and encourage people to become active participants in creating a better community. The foundation's work emerged from a concern that several public spaces and neighbourhoods were gradually becoming neglected. Issues such as public sanitation, unclean roads, poorly maintained gardens, temples and markets were affecting everyday life, yet often received limited attention. During a city-level cleanliness drive, a group of like-minded and active citizens came together and began discussing these concerns. The conversations soon led to a realisation that citizens should not merely wait for authorities to act; they could come forward, identify problems and work alongside local bodies to resolve them. This became the foundation of Anviti Foundation's approach bringing people together and turning civic responsibility into collective action.

Changing Habits, Not Just Surroundings

For Anviti Foundation, environmental work is not limited to cleaning a place after it becomes dirty. The larger objective is to change the habits and mindsets that create such problems in the first place. The foundation conducts awareness programmes and regular brainstorming sessions with schoolchildren and communities, helping them understand environmental issues and encouraging responsible behavioural patterns. Government and private school students, self-help groups, underprivileged communities and the general public are among the major groups reached through these activities. Schools are encouraged to become more environment-friendly through plantation activities, waste awareness and sustainable practices. By engaging young people and communities directly, the foundation aims to make environmental responsibility part of everyday life rather than something observed only during special occasions.

From One Market to Many

One of the foundation's notable achievements has been its effort to make a weekly vegetable market plastic-free. What began as an initiative in one market gradually developed into a model replicated across six vegetable markets in different parts of the city with the support of active citizens. The initiative demonstrated that sustainable practices can become practical when local communities participate in implementing and maintaining them. Anviti Foundation believes that simple changes, supported by awareness and consistent participation, can create visible improvements in public spaces.



Sustainability in Everyday Traditions

Waste management in temples has also become an important area of the foundation's environmental work. Religious spaces often witness large gatherings and consequently generate considerable quantities of waste. Anviti Foundation works towards encouraging better waste practices in such spaces while respecting their cultural importance. The foundation has also been celebrating Paryavaran Purak Mahashivratri for the past seven years, bringing environmental awareness into traditional celebrations. The message is clear: culture and sustainability can move together. Celebrations can retain their significance while communities become more conscious about waste, cleanliness and responsible consumption.

MEET THE FOUNDER

MRS. SHEFALI DUDHBADE



The Power of Giving

Dasn Utsav is one of Anviti Foundation's successful community initiatives, conducted monthly with minimal expenses. It connects people willing to donate useful items with those who genuinely need them. Over seven years, the foundation has organised more than 35 programmes, collecting and distributing essential materials. The initiative promotes reuse while reducing waste and supporting underprivileged families. It proves that collective giving and simple acts of kindness can create meaningful social impact.

Small Targets, Bigger Outcomes

Anviti Foundation follows the belief that large goals are achieved through smaller, measurable steps. The team generally sets 30-day short-term goals and 365-day long-term goals, followed by regular assessment and evaluation. Observations and findings from each activity help the team understand what worked, what needs improvement and how the initiative can create a stronger impact. The foundation believes that one successful event cannot alone determine community transformation. Consistent efforts over a longer period are necessary to understand whether people are actually changing their behaviour and whether the community is becoming more involved. This disciplined approach allows the foundation to move forward while keeping its activities practical and accountable.

When Collaboration Multiplies Impact

Collaboration is at the heart of many of Anviti Foundation's environmental initiatives. During a cleanliness drive at Kunwara Bhimsen, the foundation worked with the Social Forestry Department and local citizens to address littering and plastic pollution. Around 100 volunteers participated in the drive, resulting in the collection of approximately 1,000 kilograms of littered plastic. The initiative showed what can happen when citizens, government departments and community organisations work towards a common purpose. On Environment Day, the foundation also collaborated with Nagpur Metro, Western Coalfields Limited (WCL) Women's Wing, an organisation working with specially abled children, and the Central Bureau of Communication (CBC). Such partnerships allow different groups to contribute their resources, knowledge and networks towards a shared environmental goal.



A Consistent Model for Cleaner, Greener Communities

Anviti Foundation's strength lies in its consistent, community-driven approach to creating cleaner and greener neighbourhoods. Through strong governance, regular monitoring, teamwork and practical innovation, the foundation combines traditional community participation with accessible solutions that can be implemented and sustained on the ground. Its vision extends beyond individual cleanliness drives towards developing a city-level waste management model that can be replicated elsewhere. Alongside waste management, the foundation places strong emphasis on plantation not merely planting trees, but ensuring their long-term care and survival. Initiatives such as the proposed Tree Ambulance reflect this commitment, reinforcing the belief that environmental responsibility begins with action but succeeds through continuous care and collective participation.

“WHEN COMMUNITIES COME TOGETHER WITH PURPOSE, EVEN THE SMALLEST ACTIONS CAN BECOME THE FOUNDATION OF LASTING CHANGE.”

Building a Stronger Rural Future Through Collective Action

Anviti Foundation's vision extends beyond urban initiatives to building self-reliant, sustainable rural communities where clean public spaces, responsible waste management and innovative agricultural practices create better opportunities closer to home. Through its envisioned Gram Panchayat model, the foundation aims to demonstrate how villages can become centres of innovation, livelihoods and sustainable development, reflecting its belief that “Real India is Rural India.” At the same time, the foundation recognises that lasting transformation requires collective participation from individuals, organisations, CSR partners and social entrepreneurs through their time, resources, expertise and ideas. From a plastic-free market and cleaner public spaces to greener villages and stronger livelihoods, every action contributes to a larger movement. By placing citizens at the centre of change, Anviti Foundation continues to build a more responsible, resilient and sustainable future.

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FROM SWARAJ TO SELF-RELIANCE

From the freedom we inherited to the future we choose to build

Every Independence Day carries two stories. The first belongs to the generations that fought for India's freedom. The second belongs to the generations that must decide what to do with that freedom. On August 15, as the tricolour rises across the country, the celebration is not only about remembering 1947. It is also about asking what kind of India we are building today an India that can create, innovate, manufacture and compete with confidence while remaining deeply connected to its people and its heritage.

In this larger idea of nation-building, Aatma Nirbhar Bharat, or a self-reliant India, has emerged as an important national vision. The idea gained particular prominence during the COVID-19 pandemic in 2020, when India faced unprecedented disruption to supply chains, manufacturing and economic activity. On May 12, 2020, the Union Government announced a ₹20 lakh crore economic package and presented Aatma Nirbhar Bharat as a broad framework for strengthening the country's resilience. The vision was built around five pillars - Economy, Infrastructure, System, Vibrant Demography and Demand.

Self-Reliance, Reimagined

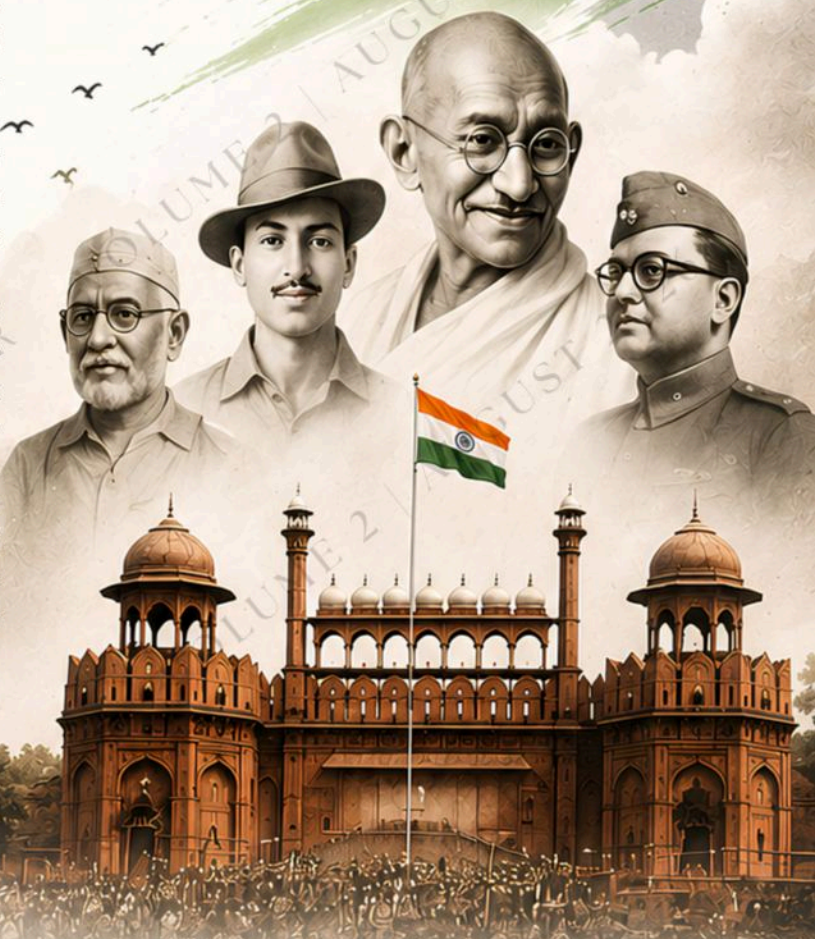
Aatma Nirbhar Bharat is often understood simply as "Make in India" or producing more goods domestically. But the larger idea goes beyond manufacturing. Self-reliance is about developing the ability to meet national needs while building the strength to participate confidently in global markets.

It does not mean that India should isolate itself from the world. Instead, it represents an ambition to become stronger within the global economy - developing domestic capabilities, encouraging innovation, strengthening supply chains and creating products that can compete internationally. This distinction is important. A self-reliant India is not an India that closes its doors. It is an India that has the confidence to open them from a position of strength.

The approach has increasingly focused on sectors where domestic capacity can have strategic importance, including electronics, pharmaceuticals, automobiles, telecommunications, renewable energy, food processing, defence and advanced technologies.

From Buying to Building

One of the most visible expressions of the Aatma Nirbhar Bharat vision has been the push towards domestic manufacturing. The Production Linked Incentive, or PLI, schemes were introduced across strategic sectors to encourage companies to manufacture in India, investment, expand production and increase exports.



As of March 31, 2026, the government reported that PLI schemes covering 14 sectors had resulted in more than ₹2.40 lakh crore of actual investment and generated more than 14.15 lakh direct and indirect jobs.

These numbers tell an important story about the direction of India's industrial policy. A mobile phone assembled in India, a pharmaceutical ingredient produced domestically, a battery manufactured for an electric vehicle or a telecom product developed by an Indian company represents more than a commercial transaction. Each reflects the gradual development of capabilities within the country. The real ambition is to move higher up the value chain from assembling products to designing them, from consuming technology to developing it and from importing critical components to creating competitive domestic alternatives.

"A self-reliant India is not one that stands apart from the world, but one confident enough to build, innovate and compete with it."

The Rise of Indian Manufacturing

India's manufacturing story has been changing rapidly. Electronics is one of the clearest examples. The expansion of mobile-phone and electronic-device manufacturing has helped India become a more important part of global supply chains. The automobile and pharmaceutical sectors have also benefited from policies designed to encourage domestic production and strengthen India's position in international markets. According to government data, PLI schemes had generated cumulative production or sales of more than ₹20.41 lakh crore and exports exceeding ₹8.3 lakh crore by December 2025, with more than 14.39 lakh direct and indirect employment opportunities reported across the 14 sectors. For a country with a large and ambitious young population, employment is one of the most important measures of economic progress.

AATMA NIRBHAR BHARAT: BUILDING INDIA, BUILDING THE FUTURE

Self-reliance is not simply about making products in India it is about creating ideas, technologies, businesses and opportunities in India. From artificial intelligence and healthcare to space technology, renewable energy, defence and telecommunications, Indian innovators are increasingly developing solutions for challenges at home while competing confidently on the global stage.

At the heart of this journey are India's MSMEs, farmers, artisans, manufacturers and local entrepreneurs. Better technology, access to finance, digital markets, food processing and stronger infrastructure can help them create greater value and stronger livelihoods. When a farmer gains access to better markets, an artisan reaches customers through digital platforms or a small manufacturer expands production, self-reliance becomes visible at the grassroots level.

INNOVATION AS THE NEW ENGINE

India's technology ecosystem is becoming a powerful engine of self-reliance. Start-ups, universities, research institutions and young innovators are working on solutions across artificial intelligence, healthcare, agriculture, clean energy and advanced manufacturing. The ambition is no longer simply to adopt technology developed elsewhere, but to design solutions that address India's own challenges—and take those solutions to the world.

STRENGTHENING INDIA'S ECONOMIC FOUNDATION

Aatma Nirbhar Bharat also depends on strengthening the foundations of the economy. Food processing, manufacturing and stronger domestic supply chains can create jobs while keeping greater value within India. Turning agricultural produce into packaged and processed products, for example, can connect farmers with industry and consumers while opening new markets for Indian businesses.

“The real freedom is not just political. It is the freedom to create, innovate and build a nation that stands tall on its own strength.”

STRATEGIC SELF-RELIANCE

In sectors such as defence, telecommunications and critical technologies, self-reliance has significance beyond economics. Building domestic capabilities can strengthen national resilience, reduce dependence on vulnerable global supply chains and create opportunities for Indian research and manufacturing. The objective is not isolation from the world, but the ability to remain competitive and secure in an interconnected global economy.

THE POWER OF YOUNG INDIA

India's greatest advantage may be its people. A young engineer developing a new product, a student launching a start-up, a woman building a local enterprise or a skilled worker entering advanced manufacturing represents a different expression of the same vision. Self-reliance begins when people move from being consumers of opportunity to creators of opportunity.

India achieved political independence in 1947. The next chapter is about strengthening the economic, technological and industrial freedom to shape our own future. This requires investment, research, skills, infrastructure and globally competitive businesses but the direction is clear. A truly Aatma Nirbhar Bharat is not an India that turns away from the world. It is an India capable of creating for the world.

Not simply Made in India - but imagined in India, built in India and ready for the world.



SUMITRA JUANGA:

A YOUNG VOICE THAT REFUSED TO STAY SILENT

A GIRL WHO SAW MORE THAN A PROBLEM

In a small village in Odisha, a young girl named Sumitra Juanga began noticing challenges that many people around her had simply learned to accept. For Sumitra, issues such as early marriage, limited opportunities for girls, health, and nutrition were not distant social problems discussed in reports they were part of the community she knew. At just 16, she chose to speak to adolescent girls and women about these issues and encourage them to think differently about their futures. Her journey is a reminder that meaningful change does not always begin with a powerful person. Sometimes, it begins with a young person who simply refuses to remain silent.

WHEN CHILDHOOD SHOULD REMAIN CHILDHOOD

One of the causes closest to Sumitra is the prevention of child marriage. She understands that childhood should be a time when girls can study, grow, dream, and discover their abilities rather than being pushed into adult responsibilities too early. Through conversations with girls and families, she encourages greater awareness about the importance of education, health, and allowing young people the time to make informed decisions about their lives. For Sumitra, protecting a girl's childhood is also about protecting her right to imagine a future for herself. A girl should have the opportunity to decide what she wants to become before being expected to decide who she will become a wife to.

SHE SPOKE BECAUSE SHE UNDERSTOOD

Sumitra's strength comes from the fact that she is part of the Juang tribal community herself. She understands the culture, surroundings, traditions, and realities of the people she works with. This makes her conversations personal and relatable. She is not speaking to her community as an outsider giving instructions; she is speaking as a young woman who understands their experiences.

That connection helps her build trust, especially with adolescent girls who may find it easier to share their concerns with someone who understands their world. Her story shows that sometimes the most effective person to create change is someone who has experienced the same environment. By bridging the gap between lived experience and actionable guidance, she transforms personal empathy into a powerful tool for community empowerment. Ultimately, her presence reassures young women that their voices are heard and that meaningful progress is truly within reach.

KNOWLEDGE CAN CHANGE A LIFE

Through the Jiban Sampark programme, Sumitra became involved in creating awareness around adolescent health, maternal health, and nutrition. These subjects may sound ordinary, but having the right information at the right time can make a life-changing difference. By sharing knowledge with women and girls, she helps bring important conversations closer to the people who need them. Her work shows that empowerment does not always begin with a large campaign or an impressive platform. Sometimes, it starts with one honest conversation, one question answered, or one person gaining the confidence to make a better decision.

Knowledge gives people the ability to question, choose, and act. For young girls especially, understanding their health and rights can help them make decisions with greater confidence. Sumitra's efforts therefore go beyond simply sharing information they help create an environment where girls can begin to believe that their voices matter. By encouraging open conversations, she helps break the silence around issues that are often overlooked or misunderstood. Her work also inspires girls to seek support, express their concerns, and take greater ownership of their futures. In doing so, she is helping build a generation of young women who are informed, confident, and empowered to shape their own lives.

A TEENAGER WITH A PURPOSE

At an age when many teenagers are still discovering their own dreams, Sumitra was already thinking about the well-being of the people around her. She did not wait for a degree, a job title, or a position of authority before taking responsibility. She simply stepped forward. That is what makes her journey so inspiring. Her leadership did not begin with power; it began with empathy. She saw people facing challenges and decided that doing something, however small, was better than remaining silent.

Her story is particularly powerful for young readers because it breaks the idea that age is a barrier to meaningful contribution. A young person can listen, learn, speak, support others, and begin creating change long before receiving a formal title.

THE POSITIVE CHANGE SHE CREATES

Sumitra's work represents a form of change that begins within the community itself. Her efforts contribute to awareness about preventing child marriage, adolescent and maternal health, nutrition, and the importance of informed choices for girls and women. But her impact goes beyond these subjects. When a girl begins believing that she has choices, when a mother receives information that can improve her family's well-being, or when a family begins reconsidering an early marriage, change has already begun.

These individual moments may seem small, but together they can influence an entire community. A conversation can change a decision. A decision can change the future. And a changed future can influence the next generation.

SHE DIDN'T WAIT TO BE A HERO

Sumitra never needed to call herself a leader. Her actions speak for her. She chose to help other girls understand their rights and possibilities instead of simply accepting that circumstances could never change. Her story reminds us that a hero does not always stand on a stage or receive applause. Sometimes, a hero is a young person who notices a problem, finds the courage to speak, and keeps trying to make things better. Her journey is a powerful example of how young people can become agents of positive change in their own communities. She demonstrates that leadership is not necessarily about having authority over others; it can be about having the courage to stand beside others.

THE RIPPLE EFFECT OF ONE VOICE

The most meaningful impact of Sumitra's work may be found in the changes that happen quietly. It could be a girl deciding to continue her education, a family choosing to delay a daughter's marriage, or a mother becoming more aware of her health and nutrition. These moments may never become headlines, but they can change the direction of a life.

One informed decision can influence a family, and one empowered family can influence a community. This is the ripple effect that makes grassroots leadership so powerful. Change does not always arrive as a dramatic event. More often, it grows slowly through conversations, awareness, trust, and courage.

WHY HER STORY MATTERS

Sumitra's story matters because it represents thousands of young people who want a better future for their communities but may not have a large platform to express themselves. Her journey reminds us to look beyond age, background, geography, and social status when we think about leadership.

She also reminds us that empowerment is not about speaking for people it is about helping people find the confidence to speak for themselves. By encouraging girls and women to understand their choices and make informed decisions, Sumitra is helping create stronger individuals who can contribute to stronger communities.

A MESSAGE FOR EVERY YOUNG PERSON

Sumitra Juanga's journey is a reminder that age does not determine the size of your impact. You do not need wealth, fame, or a massive platform to make a difference. You can begin with the people around you, with the knowledge you have, and with the problems you genuinely care about. Her journey tells young people something important: do not underestimate the power of starting small. You may not be able to change an entire society overnight, but you can influence one person, help one family, or inspire one young girl to believe in herself. Sometimes, that is enough to begin a movement.

A STORY THAT REACHED UNICEF

Sumitra's journey gained national attention when UNICEF India highlighted her work with adolescent girls and women in Odisha. Her path shows how meaningful leadership often begins quietly in rural communities through simple, everyday conversations. Starting with nothing more than a deep concern for her community, Sumitra turned empathy into action. By finding the courage to speak up, she now inspires countless other young women to believe that their voices matter too. Her journey demonstrates how individual determination, when combined with a genuine commitment to community welfare, can create a lasting ripple effect. What began as a personal concern has gradually grown into a larger story of awareness, confidence, and collective empowerment.

Her story also reflects the power of grassroots leadership to create change that extends far beyond one community. By making conversations around health, dignity, education and rights more open and accessible, Sumitra has helped young girls see possibilities beyond the limitations placed before them. Her journey is a reminder that when one person chooses to listen, speak and act, that courage can become a source of confidence for many others. Through her continued efforts, she is helping create safer spaces where young women can share their experiences without fear or hesitation.

STEM EDUCATION

Where Curiosity Meets Creation

More Than Four Letters

A child sees a broken toy and wonders, "Can I fix it?" Another looks at a computer and asks, "How does this work?" Someone else sees a problem in their community and thinks, "There must be a better way." These simple moments of curiosity are where STEM education begins. STEM stands for Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics. But it is not just about studying four subjects. It is about helping students connect what they learn in school with what they see around them.

Instead of simply memorising a formula, students might use mathematics to design a structure. Instead of reading only about electricity, they might build a circuit. Instead of learning computer concepts from a textbook, they might write a simple program themselves.

The focus is on understanding, trying, making mistakes and trying again. And that is what makes STEM different. It gives children the freedom to move from being learners to becoming creators.

Where Did STEM Begin?

Science, mathematics, engineering and technology are certainly not new. Long before the word STEM existed, ancient civilizations were building remarkable structures, studying the stars, developing mathematical systems and finding practical solutions to everyday problems. The modern STEM education framework developed in the United States. The growing importance of science and technology during the 20th century played a major role in its development. The launch of the Soviet satellite Sputnik in 1957 was an especially important moment. It encouraged the United States to strengthen science and mathematics education and invest more heavily in scientific research and education.

The word STEM itself came later. The U.S. National Science Foundation had earlier used the term "SMET" for Science, Mathematics, Engineering and Technology. In 2001, it adopted the term "STEM," which became the name widely used for this integrated approach to education. So, while science and mathematics belong to humanity as a whole and have deep roots across many civilizations, the United States was the country that formally developed and popularised the modern STEM framework.



STEM Finds Its Place in India

India's connection with science and mathematics goes back centuries. From ancient mathematical discoveries and astronomical observations to advances in medicine, engineering and architecture, scientific thinking has always been part of India's story. However, the modern idea of bringing Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics together through hands-on learning gained significant momentum in India in the 21st century.

One of the major milestones came in 2016, when the Government of India launched the Atal Innovation Mission (AIM) under NITI Aayog. Among its key initiatives were Atal Tinkering Laboratories (ATLs) in schools. The idea behind these laboratories was simple but powerful: give students a place where they could touch, build, experiment and create instead of only reading about concepts in textbooks.

Students were introduced to areas such as robotics, electronics, sensors, computing, 3D printing and other emerging technologies. More importantly, they were encouraged to identify problems around them and think about possible solutions. For many children, this represented a different kind of classroom. A desk was no longer just a place to write an answer it could become the starting point for an invention.

India has continued to expand its focus on innovation and STEM learning. By 2025, the Government of India reported that 10,000 Atal Tinkering Laboratories had been established across the country, reaching more than 1.1 crore students. India has also taken steps to encourage greater participation of girls in science and technology. Initiatives such as Vigyan Jyoti aim to encourage girls, particularly from areas where women are underrepresented in STEM, to pursue science-related education and careers. India's STEM journey, therefore, is not simply about adding technology to classrooms. It is about changing the experience of learning—from “What should I remember?” to “What can I understand, create and improve?”



When the Classroom Comes Alive

One of the most interesting things about STEM is that it can make an ordinary classroom feel completely different. A lesson does not always have to end when the textbook closes. Students can build models, conduct experiments, work with robotics, learn coding, collect information, analyse results and create their own designs. A lesson about clean energy, for example, could become an opportunity to build a small solar-powered model. There is something powerful about watching an idea take shape in front of you. A student may build something that does not work the first time. They may make a wrong calculation or discover that their design is not strong enough. Instead of simply being told that they are wrong, they can ask what happened, make changes and try once more. That experience teaches a valuable lesson: getting something wrong is sometimes the first step towards getting it right.

STEM Is Already Around Us

We often talk about technology as if it belongs to the future. In reality, it is already deeply woven into our everyday lives. The phone in our hands is the result of scientific research, engineering, mathematics and software development. Electric vehicles depend on advances in batteries and engineering. Weather forecasts use complex data and mathematical models. Hospitals rely on technology for scanning, monitoring and treatment. Farmers increasingly use sensors, satellite information and digital tools to make better decisions. Behind many of the things we now take for granted are people who once asked a simple question:

“What if we could do this differently?”

STEM education helps young people develop the habit of asking that question themselves.

Preparing Young Minds for a Different World

The world students are growing up in is changing rapidly, with AI, automation, biotechnology, renewable energy and digital technologies reshaping the future of work. What matters is not preparing every child for one specific career, but helping them develop skills that remain valuable across professions critical thinking, problem-solving, collaboration, adaptability and decision-making. STEM provides a strong foundation, but where that foundation takes them is limited only by their imagination.

Empowering the Next Generation Through STEM

STEM education gives every child, regardless of background, the opportunity to explore, create and solve real-world problems. With access to the right tools, teachers and practical experiences, a simple classroom idea can grow into a solution that benefits an entire community. More than formulas, coding or technology, STEM builds curiosity, critical thinking, problem-solving and adaptability skills that remain valuable across careers and throughout life. It also helps students see that their ideas can have a purpose beyond examinations and classrooms.

The future will bring new technologies, careers and challenges that we cannot fully predict. But with the right foundation, today's students can face them with knowledge, confidence and courage. Every great invention begins with an idea, every breakthrough begins with a question, and every change begins with someone willing to ask, “What if we tried?” When children are given the opportunity to ask that question, they are not just preparing for the future they are gaining the ability to shape it. By nurturing their curiosity today, we can empower them to build a smarter, more innovative and more inclusive tomorrow. The future is not something they simply inherit; it is something they have the power to create.

“STEM DOES NOT JUST PREPARE CHILDREN FOR THE FUTURE; IT EMPOWERS THEM TO CREATE THE FUTURE THEY IMAGINE.”

WORD SEARCH

FIND THE WORDS. GET INSPIRED.

Find and circle the words hidden in the grid.



Word list:

BLIZZARD	FROST	OVERCAST	STORM
CLOUD	GUST	PRESSURE	STRATUS
DEWPOINT	HAIL	RAIN	THUNDER
DROUGHT	HEATWAVE	RAINBOW	TORNADO
ECLIPSE	HURRICANE	SLEET	TYPHOON
FLOOD	LIGHTNING	SNOWFLAKE	WILDFIRE
FOG	MIST	SNOWSTORM	WIND



SUDOKU

FOCUS. THINK. SOLVE

Fill in the empty boxes so that each row, column and 3*3 box contains the numbers 1 to 9 only once.

PUZZLE 1

1				8				9
	5		6	1		2		
			5		3			
	9	6	1		4	8	3	
3				6				5
	1	5	9		8	4	6	
			7		5			
	8		3	9		7		
5				1				3

DIFFICULTY LEVEL : MEDIUM

PUZZLE 2

6		3						
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	8					4		
	7			9			1	
		6			7		2	
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4					9		5	
						1		6

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“

Sudoku teaches us that every challenge has a solution; sometimes, all it takes is patience, logic, and the courage to try again.

”



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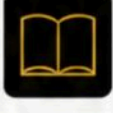
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